

Left Turn

A Quarterly Journal of Critical Voices



**Richard Falk on the Vietnam War, Revolution
in Iran, & Genocide in Gaza**

Faramarz Farbod

**It's Debatable: Talking Authentically
about Tricky Topics**

Robert Jensen

Patriarchal Pronatalism

Nandita Bajaj

Student Intifada Links With Global Struggles

Gary Olson

Hyper-Imperialism

Tricontinental: Institute for Social Research

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Notes from the Editors

“From the River to the Sea Palestine will be free”

The morally-depraved US ruling class and its subservient media manipulate the “conversation” about this chant in at least two ways:

- They propagate the disingenuous Zionist view that the chant calls for the killing or removal of all Jews in historical Palestine. Anyone who knows anything about the Palestinian struggle for justice and self-determination knows that this chant is a call for equality for all peoples in Palestine, including the Jews.
- They never point out that the Israeli ruling class has not only declared Jewish supremacy over all the land between the river to the sea but that it has been state policy and the reality on the ground for decades, even predating the formation of Hamas. Behold Bibi Netanyahu’s words uttered in a closed-door meeting of Likud legislators at a Jerusalem Heritage center in March of 2019: “We will rule over all the territory west of the Jordan, we will be everywhere... We won’t uproot even one [Jewish] person. No one will be uprooted.”

This manipulation by the US, the chief enabler of Israel’s genocide in Gaza, is an aspect of its neo-McCarthyite campaign at home to silence Palestinian solidarity activists. To the ruling class, silencing those who shout “from the river to the sea, Palestine will be free” is more important than ending a live-streaming genocide now well into its ninth month with nearly 40,000 deaths, close to 90,000 injured, thousands dead and unaccounted for under the rubble, some 70% of building structures destroyed or damaged, almost all the 2.3 million Palestinians living in Gaza displaced multiple times, and starvation used as a weapon against them, not to speak of the exacerbation of oppression in the West Bank.

As catastrophic as the situation has been for Palestinians, the US-backed Israeli genocide in Gaza offers little hope of victory for Israel or ending anytime soon despite Biden administration’s concerns that its full backing of this genocide may cost it the coming November presidential elections. Biden no doubt would like to see a ceasefire,

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Richard Falk on the Vietnam War, Revolution in Iran, & Genocide in Gaza

FARAMARZ FARBOD

Editor's Note: This is a lightly-edited transcript of my conversation with Professor Richard Falk that aired on 23 January 2024 on Berks Community TV (BCTV).

Faramarz Farbod: You have taught at Princeton University for four decades; you were the UN Special Rapporteur for Human Rights in the Occupied Palestinian Territories in Israel (2008–2014); and you are the author of numerous books about global issues and international law. In preparation for this conversation, I have been reading your autobiography, *Public Intellectual: The Life of a Citizen Pilgrim* (2019). Tell us about yourself and how you became politically engaged in your own words.

Richard Falk: I grew up in New York City in a kind of typical middle-class, post-religious, Jewish family that had a lot of domestic stress because I had an older sister with mental issues who was hospitalized for most of her life. This caused my parents to divorce because they saw the issues in a very different way. I was brought up by my father. He was a lawyer and quite right-wing, a Cold War advocate, and a friend of some of the prominent people who were anticommunists at that time, including Kerensky, the interim Prime Minister of Russia after the revolution between the Czar and Lenin. My father had a kind of entourage of anti-communist people who were frequent guests. So, I grew up in this kind of conservative, secular environment, post-religious, post any kind of significant cultural relationship to my ethnically Jewish identity.

I attended a fairly progressive private school that I didn't like too much because I was more interested in sports than academics at that stage of my life. I managed to go to the university and gradually became more academically oriented. I was jolted into a fit of realism by being on academic probation after my first year at the University of Pennsylvania. That scared me enough that I became a better student. I went to law school after graduating from the Wharton School at the University of Pennsylvania, majoring in economics. But I knew I didn't want to be a lawyer in the way my father was. So, it was a very puzzling time. I studied Indian law and language to make myself irrelevant to the law scene in the US. I never thought of myself as an academic because of the mediocre academic record I had managed to compile. When I graduated from law school, I was supposed to go to India on a Fulbright, but it was canceled at the last minute because India hadn't paid for some grain under the Public Law-480 program [commonly known as Food for Peace signed into law by President Eisenhower in 1954 to liquidate US surplus agricultural products and increasingly used as a policy tool to advance US strategic and diplomatic interests

with "friendly" nations]. It turned out Ohio State University was so desperate to fill a vacancy created by the sickness of one of its faculty that they hired me as a visiting professor. I realized immediately that it was a good way out for me. I managed to stay there for six years until I went to Princeton for 40 years.

I became gradually liberated from my father's conservatism and achieved a certain kind of political identity while opposing the Vietnam War. That took a very personal turn when I was invited to go to Vietnam in 1968. There I encountered the full force of what it meant to be a Third World country seeking national independence and yet be opposed by colonial and post-colonial intervention. I was very impressed by the Vietnamese leadership, which I had the opportunity to meet. It was very different from the East European and Soviet leadership that I had earlier been in contact with. They were very humanistic and intelligent and oriented toward a kind of post-war peace with the US. They were more worried about China than they were about the US because China was their traditional enemy. But it made me see the world from a different perspective. I felt personally transformed and identified with their struggle for independence and the courage and friendship they exhibited towards me.

FF: What did you teach at Princeton University?

RF: My academic background was in international law. Princeton had no law school, so in a way, I was a disciplinary refugee. I began teaching international relations as well as international law. The reason they hired me was that they had an endowed chair in international law instead of a law school and they hadn't been able to find anyone who was trained in law but not so interested in it. They tracked me down in Ohio State and offered me this very good academic opportunity. They invited me as a visiting professor first and then some years later offered me this chair which had accumulated a lot of resources because they had been unable to fill this position and I was able to have a secretary and research assistants and other kinds of perks that are not normal even at a rich university like Princeton. I felt more kind of an outsider there in terms of both social background and political orientation, but it was a very privileged place to be in many ways that had very good facilities, and I was still enough of an athlete to use the tennis and squash courts as a mode of daily therapy.

FF: Why would the Vietnamese leadership invite you to come to Vietnam to meet them? Was it because you were a professor at a prestigious university, which gave you an elite status, or was it something else?

RF: I think it was partly because of my background. I had written some law journal articles that had gotten a bit of attention, and somebody must have recommended me. I don't know. I was somewhat surprised. I was supposed to go with a well-known West Coast author considered a left person, but she got sick, and I was accompanied by a very young lawyer. So, I was basically on my own, inexperienced, and didn't know what to expect. It seemed a risky thing to do from a professional point of view because I was going as an opponent of an ongoing war. There was a 19th-century

law that said if you engage in private diplomacy, you're subject to some kind of criminal prosecution. I didn't know what to anticipate. But it turned out this was at a time when the US was at least pretending to seek a peaceful negotiation to end its involvement. So, when I came back, because I had these meetings with the Prime Minister and others who had given me a peace proposal that was better than what Kissinger negotiated many deaths later during the Nixon presidency. The US government, rather than prosecuting me, came to debrief me and invited me to the State Department and so on, which was something of a surprise.

FF: Did the State Department take this peace proposal seriously?

RF: I don't know what happened internally in the government. I made them aware of it. It was given front-page *New York Times* coverage for a couple of days. There was this atmosphere at that time, in the spring of 1968, that was disposed toward finding some way out of this impasse that had been reached in the war itself. The war couldn't be won, and the phrase of that time was "peace with honor" though it was hard to have much honor after all the devastation that had been carried out.

FF: What were the elements of that peace proposal given to you that were striking to you?

RF: The thing that surprised me was that they agreed to allow a quite large number of American troops to stay in Vietnam and to be present while a pre-election was internationally monitored in the southern part of Vietnam. They envisioned some kind of coalition government emerging from those elections. It was quite forthcoming given the long struggle and the heavy casualties they had endured. It was a war in which the future in a way was anticipated; the US completely dominated the military dimensions of the war, land, sea, and air, but managed to lose the war. That puzzle between having military superiority and yet failing to control the political outcome is a pattern that was repeated in several places, including later in Afghanistan and Iraq.

It is a lesson the US elites can not learn. They are unable to learn because of the strength of the military-industrial-congressional complex. They can't accept the limited agency of military power in the post-colonial world. Therefore, they keep repeating this Vietnam pattern in different forms. They learned some political lessons like not having as much TV coverage of the US casualties. One of the things that was often said by those who supported the war was that it wasn't lost in Vietnam; it was lost in US living rooms. Years later, we heard the same concerns with "embedded" journalists with combat forces, for instance, in the first Gulf War. It was a time when they abolished the draft and relied on a voluntary, professional armed forces. They did their best to pacify American political engagement through more control of the media and other techniques. But it didn't change this pattern of heavy military involvement and political disappointment.

FF: This pattern may be repeating itself in Gaza as we speak. But I would like to ask you a follow up question. You said that the reason essentially for the persistence of that pattern is the existence of a powerful military-industrial-congressional com-

plex. Are you assuming that the US political leadership wishes to learn the hard lessons but gets blocked by the influence of this complex? Could it be that the US ruling class is in fact so immersed in imperial consciousness that it cannot learn the right lessons after all? When the US leaders look at debacles in Afghanistan, Iraq, and Vietnam, don't they seek to learn lessons to pursue their imperial policies more effectively the next time? Which of these perspectives is closer to reality in your thinking?

RF: The essential point is that the political gatekeepers only select potential leaders who either endorse or consider it a necessity to go along with this consensus as to putting the military budget above partisan politics and making it a matter of bipartisan consensus with small agreements at the margins about whether this or that weapon system should be given priority and greater resource. Occasionally one or two people in Congress will challenge that kind of idea but nothing politically significant in terms of friction. There's no friction in terms of this way of seeing the projection of US influence in the post-colonial world.

FF: Let's assume that's correct, and I think you're right about that. But why is that the case? Is it because the US political class knows that a modern capitalist political economy and state needs this military-industrial complex as a kind of floor to the economy, that this floor needs to exist, otherwise, if you remove it, stagnationist tendencies will prevail? Is this military industrial floor a requirement of modern US capitalism? Is that why they're thinking in this way?

RF: It is a good question. I'm not sure. I think that the core belief is one that's deep in the political culture. That somehow strength is measured by military capabilities and the underrating of other dimensions of influence and leadership. This is sustained by Wall Street kind of perspectives that see the arms industry as very important component of the economy and by the government bureaucracy that became militarized as a consequence first of World War II and then along the Cold War. It overbalanced support for the military as a kind of essential element of government credibility. You couldn't break into those Washington elites unless you were seen as a supporter of this level of consensus. It's similar in a way to the unquestioning bipartisan support for Israel, which was, until this Gaza crisis, beyond political questioning, and still is beyond political questioning in Washington, despite it being subjected for the first time to serious political doubts among the citizens.

FF: I think you're right. There is a cultural element here in addition to the uses of military Keynesianism for domestic economic reasons and for imperial reasons to project power. I want to ask you one final question about your reflections on Vietnam. What was the quarrel about from the US perspective? Why was the US so keen on having decades of engagement after the French were defeated in early 1950s all the way to mid 1970s? Why did the US engage in such destructive behavior?

RF: I think there are two main reasons. Look at the *Pentagon Papers* that were released by Daniel Ellsberg; they were a study of the US involvement in Vietnam.

FF: In 1971.

RF: Yes in 1971, but they go back to the beginning of the engagement. The US didn't even distinguish between Vietnam and China. They called the Vietnamese *Chicom*s in those documents. Part of the whole motivation was this obsession with containing China after its revolution in 1949. The second idea was this falling-dominoes image that if Vietnam went in a communist direction, other countries in the region would follow and that would have a significant bearing on the global balance and on the whole geopolitics of containment. The third reason was the US trying to exhibit solidarity with the French, who had been defeated in the Indochina war, and to at least limit the scope of that defeat and assert a kind of Western ideological hegemony in the rest of Vietnam.

FF: I think Indonesia was probably more important from the US perspective. Once there was a successful US-backed coup d'état in 1965, some in the US argued that perhaps it's over. The US has won and achieved its strategic objectives by securing Indonesia from falling in the image of the falling dominoes. The US could have gotten out of Vietnam then. But it didn't. Maybe this was because of concerns about losing credibility. Do you have any thoughts on this matter?

RF: Yes, that's a very important observation and it's hard to document because people don't acknowledge it fully. The support that the US and particularly CIA gave to the Indonesian effort at genocidal assault on the Sukarno elements of pro-Marxist, anti-Western constituents there resulted in a very deadly killing fields. Indonesia was from a resource and a geopolitical point of view far more important than Vietnam. But Vietnam had built-up a constituency within the armed forces and the counterinsurgency specialists that created a strong push to demonstrate that the US could succeed in this kind of war. The defeat which eventually was acknowledged in effect was thought correctly to inhibit support within the United States for future regime changing interventions and other kinds of foreign policy.

FF: Let's move on to another politically engaged episode in your life. You were engaged with the revolutionary processes in Iran in late 1970s. You even met Ayatollah Khomeini in a three-hour-long meeting prior to his departure from Paris to Iran in early 1979 when he founded the Islamic Republic and assumed its Supreme Leadership until his death in 1989. What were your thoughts about the Iranian revolution? And what are your reflections today given the vantage point of 45 years of post-revolutionary history? Also tell us what were your impressions of Ayatollah Khomeini in that long meeting you had with him?

RF: My initial involvement with Iran was a consequence of several Iranian students of mine who were active. Princeton had several prominent meetings in 1978 during the year of the revolution. As a person who had been involved with Vietnam, I was approached by these students to speak and to be involved with their activities. They were all at least claiming to be victims of SAVAK, the Iranian intelligence service under the Shah that was accused of torturing people in prison. I was convinced that after Vietnam, the next place the US would be involved in a regressive manner would be in Iran in support the Shah. Recall that Henry Kissinger in his book on diplomacy says that the Shah was the rarest of things and an unconditional US ally.

By that he meant that he did things for Israel that were awkward even for the US to do and he supplied energy to South Africa during the apartheid period. This sense that there would be a confrontation of some sort in Iran guided my early thinking. Then I also had this friendship with Mansour Farhang, who was an intellectual opponent of the Shah's regime [and later the revolutionary Iran's first ambassador to the UN] and represented the Iranian *bazaari* [pertaining to the traditional merchant class] view of Iranian politics that objected to the Shah's efforts at neoliberal economic globalization. All that background accounted for my invitation to visit Iran and learn first-hand what the revolution was about.

I went with the former US Attorney General Ramsey Clark and a young religious leader. We spent two quite fascinating weeks in Iran in the moment of maximum ferment because the Shah left the country while we were there. It was a very interesting psychological moment. The people we were with in the city of Qazvin on the day the Shah left couldn't believe it. They thought it was a trick to get people to show their real political identity as a prelude to a new round of repression. During the Carter presidency, the US was very supportive of the Shah's use of force in suppressing internal revolt. They had an interval at [the September 1978] Camp David talks, seeking peace between Egypt and Israel, to congratulate the Shah on the shooting of demonstrators [on 8 September in Jaleh Square] in Tehran. That was seen as the epitome of interference in Iran's internal politics.

After our visit, we met many religious leaders and secular opponents of the Shah's government. It was a time when Carter sent the NATO General Huyser to Iran to try to help the armed forces. Because our visit went well, we were given the impression that as a reward for our visit we would have this meeting with Khomeini in Paris, which we did. My impression was of a very severe individual, but very intelligent, with very strong eyes that captured your attention. He was impressive in the sense that he started the meeting by asking us questions—quite important ones as things turned out. His main question was: Did we think the US would intervene as it had in the past in 1953 against Mossadeq? Would the US repeat that kind of intervention in the present context? He went on to add that if the US did not intervene, he saw no obstacle to the normalization of relations. That view was echoed by the US ambassador in Iran, William Sullivan, during our meeting with him. Khomeini objected to speaking of the Iranian revolution and insisted on calling it the Islamic revolution. He extended his condemnation of the Shah's dynasty to Saudi Arabia and the gulf monarchies arguing that they were as decadent and exploitative as was the Shah. He used a very colorful phrase that I remember to this day, which was the Shah had created "a river of blood" between the state and society. His own private ambition was to return to Iran and resume his religious life. He did not want to be a political leader at that point at least or he may not have understood the degree of support that he enjoyed in Iran at that time. He did go back to the religious city of Qom and resumed a religious life but was led to believe that Bazargan, the Prime Minister of Iran's interim government, was putting people in charge of running the country who were sacrificing revolutionary goals.

FF: When you met Ayatollah Khomeini, were you aware of the series of lectures he had given in the early 1970s in Najaf while in exile in Iraq that were smuggled via audio cassettes into mosque networks inside Iran and later published as a book titled *Islamic Government: Governance of the Jurist*? Some people knew that he had those ideas about an Islamic state, but he did not talk about it in Paris. Did he talk about it when you met him?

RF: He didn't talk about it. I was superficially familiar with it. Among the people we met in Tehran was a mathematician who was very familiar with that part of Khomeini's writing and was scared by what it portended. Of course, Khomeini, as I said, did not anticipate or at least said he did not anticipate his own political leadership, and may have regarded that vision in his writing as something he hoped to achieve but did not necessarily think of himself as the agent of its implementation. I have no idea about that.

FF: In retrospect, what are your general reflections looking back on Iran's revolution?

RF: One set of reflections is the revolution's durability. Whatever failures it has had, it has successfully resisted its internal, regional, and global adversaries. If it had not been tough on its opponents, it probably would not have survived very long. The comparison, for instance, with the Arab Spring's failures to sustain their upheavals is quite striking, particularly when comparing the failure of the Egyptian movement to sustain itself with the Iranian experience and resistance.

The second thing is disappointment at the failure to develop in more humane directions and the extreme harshness of the treatment of people perceived as their opponent. In that sense, there is no doubt that it has become a repressive theocratic autocracy. But countries like Israel and the US are not completely without some responsibility for that development. There was a kind of induced paranoia in a way because they had real opponents who tried to destabilize it in a variety of ways. The West encouraged Iraq to attack Iran and gave it a kind of green light. The attack involved the idea that they could at least easily control the oil producing parts of Iran, if not bring about the fall of the Khomeini-style regime itself. As often is the case in the US-induced use of force overseas, there are a lot of miscalculations, probably on both sides.

FF: The US has viewed Iran ever since its revolution as a threat to its geostrategic interests. I think that the "threat" is more the deterrence power of Iran, in other words, Iran's ability to impose a cost on US operations in the region, oftentimes targeting Iran itself. And of course, Israel, too, is in alliance with the US. Do you agree with this assessment that there is basically no threat to the United States from Iran aside from Iran's ability to impose costs on US operations in the region, oftentimes against Iran itself?

RF: I completely agree with that. Iran had initially especially at most an anti-imperial outlook that did not want interference with the national movement. Of course, it wanted to encourage Islamic movements throughout the region and had a certain success. That was viewed in Washington as a geopolitical threat. It was certainly

not a national security threat in the conventional sense. But it could be viewed as a threat to the degree to which US hegemony could be maintained in the strategic energy policies that were very important to the US at that time.

FF: Let's shift to Palestine-Israel. What is the appropriate historical context for understanding what happened on Oct. 7 and what has been taking place since then in Gaza and the West Bank? We know that the conventional US view distorts reality by talking about this issue as if history began on 7 October with the Hamas attack on southern Israel.

RF: This is a complicated set of issues to unravel in a brief conversation. But there is no question that the context of the Hamas attack is crucial to understanding its occurrence, even though the attack itself needs to be problematized in terms of whether Israel wanted it to happen or let it happen. They had adequate advance warning; they had all that surveillance technology along the borders with Gaza. The IDF did not respond as it usually does in a short period. It took them five hours, apparently, to arrive at the scene of these events. On the one side, we really don't know how to perceive that October 7 event. We do know that some worse aspects of it, the beheading of babies, mass rapes, and those kinds of horrifying details, were being manipulated by Israel and its supporters. So, we need an authoritative reconstruction of October 7 itself.

But even without that reconstruction, we know that Hamas and the Palestinians were being provoked by a series of events. There is a kind of immediate context where Netanyahu goes to the UN General Assembly and waves a map with Palestine essentially erased from it. To Netanyahu, this is the new Middle East without Palestine in it. He has made it clear recently that he is opposed to any kind of Palestinian statehood. So, one probable motivation was for the Palestinians to reassert their presence or existence and resolve to remain.

The other very important contextual element is the recollection of the Nakba or catastrophe that occurred in 1948 where 750,000 Palestinians were forced to flee from their homes and villages and not permitted to return. The Israeli response since October 7 gives rise to a strong impression that the real motivation on its part is not security as it is ordinarily understood but rather a second Nakba to ethnically cleanse and to implement this by the forced evacuation and unlivability of Gaza carried out by what many people, including myself, have regarded as a genocide.

The Israeli argument that they are entitled to act in self-defense seems very strained in this context. Gaza and the West Bank are, from an international law point of view, occupied territories; they are not foreign entities. How do you exercise self-defense against yourself? The Geneva Accords are very clear that the primary duty of the occupying power is to protect the civilian population. It is an unconditional duty of the occupying power, and it is spelled out in terms of an unconditional obligation, to make sure that the population has sufficient food and medical supplies, which the Israeli leadership from day one excluded. They tried to block the entry of food,

fuel, and electricity and have caused a severe health-starvation scenario that will probably cost many more lives than have already been lost.

FF: Not to speak of another violation by Israel: As an occupying power it is prohibited from transferring its own population to the territories that it has been occupying.

RF: Yes.

FF: Of course, Israeli expansionism in terms of its settlements, practically does away with the viability of the idea of a two-state solution, unless somehow, they can be forced to remove all the settlers and dismantle the major settlement blocks in the West Bank.

Let me get your thoughts on the following. It seems Israel used October 7 as an excuse to carry out a speedier mass expulsion campaign rather than to continue with the slower ethnic cleansing that oftentimes characterize its actions in various decades in the period of Israeli control over these territories. We can point to 1948 and 1967 as two other occasions when Israel took advantage of historical moments and expelled many Palestinians. Post-Oct. 7 may be the third historical moment in which Israel is behaving in this manner. Do you agree with this assessment?

RF: Absolutely. The only thing I would add is that the Netanyahu coalition with religious Zionism as it took over in Israel in January of 2023 was widely viewed, even in Washington, as the most extreme government that had ever come to power in Israel. What made it extreme was the green lighting of settler violence in the West Bank, which was clearly aimed at dispossessing the Palestinian presence there. They often at these settler demonstrations would leave on Palestinian cars these messages: “leave or we will kill you.” It is horrifying that this dimension of Israeli provocation has not been taken into some account.

FF: Yes, we see that in the West Bank since October 7. By now some 16 villages have been depopulated, several hundred Palestinians killed, and close to 6,000 arrested by the Israeli Offensive (not Defensive) Forces who often act alongside armed settlers who enjoy impunity in terrorizing the Palestinians.

Well, thank you, Richard, for joining me in this conversation. I found it to be very interesting.

RF: Thank you and I also found your questions very suggestive and a challenge.

Richard Falk is a leading international law professor emeritus at Princeton University, prominent activist, UN Special Rapporteur for Occupied Palestine (2008–2014), and pioneer thinker dedicated to peace and justice. He has been nominated annually since 2009 for the Nobel Peace Prize. He is a prolific author, including the upcoming Ukraine in the Shadow of Geopolitics, and most recently, Protecting Human Rights in Occupied Palestine.

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Hyper-Imperialism: A Dangerous Decadent New Stage

TRICONTINENTAL: INSTITUTE FOR SOCIAL RESEARCH

Our latest study explores how the decline of Global North hegemony has shifted the geopolitical landscape and opened new possibilities for emergent organisations of the Global South.

It has been a scant 30 years since the ‘end of history’ was declared by bourgeois ideologists in pantomimes of wish-fulfilment for sensing the inviolability of United States imperialism.¹ For peoples’ struggles and movements feeling the boot of imperialism on their necks, no such end was in sight.

In the face of violent repression, such as Brazil’s Carajás Massacre in 1996, the Landless Workers’ Movement led the reclamation of land for popular agrarian reform through occupation and production, challenging agribusiness behemoths, such as the US multinational Monsanto.² A ‘soldier who shook the continent’, Hugo Chávez won the popular vote in 1999, a sharp left turn that was followed by others in Latin America. This included a wave of mass mobilisation of millions of workers, peasants, Indigenous, women, and students that defeated the proposed US Free Trade Areas of the Americas in 2005, a direct challenge to nearly 200 years of the US Monroe Doctrine.³

In 2002, Nigerian women gathered at the gates of Shell and Chevron to protest environmental destruction and exploitation in the Niger Delta. Haitians refused the centuries of denigration in mass demonstrations following the US ousting of Jean-Bertrand Aristide and US occupation in 2004. Millions of Nepalese celebrated the toppling of the monarchy through armed resistance under the leadership of the communists in 2006. When fruit vendor Mohamed Bouazizi set himself on fire in 2010, the Tunisian people revolted against the neo-liberal system that had caused him to take such extreme measures.

In subsequent years, changes — sometimes small and imperceptible, at other times volatile and explosive — unfolded. These involved both popular movements and state actors, in some cases extremely powerful ones. The US was confronted by a rising economic powerhouse in China, growing economies in the Global South (which overtook the Global North’s GDP in PPP [Purchasing Power Parity] terms in 2007), years of domestic capital investment neglect, the financialisation of the economy, and the loss of manufacturing superiority.

The rise of the Tea Party in 2009 signalled internal fracturing of US domestic politics. Internationally, the US failed to achieve soft regime disruption in China and de-nuclearisation or regime change in Russia. After a temporary reduction in military spending with the end of the disastrous war on Iraq (2003–2011), the US shifted to the use and threat of military power as a central pillar of its response to these changes.

Hegemony is historically lost in three stages: production, finance, and military.⁴ The United States has lost hegemony in production, though it still has some remaining areas of technological hegemony, including those related to the military. It is seeing its financial hegemony challenged, though still in the very early stages and revolving around the status of the US dollar. Even though the economic and political aspects of its decline might be accelerating, it still retains military power—creating a temptation for the US to attempt to overcome the consequences of its economic decline by military or military related means.

The US has defined China as its strategic competitor. The minimum programme of the US is the containment and economic diminishment of China, sufficient to guarantee the US's own perpetual future economic hegemony.

From its own point of view, US capitalism is rational in its attempts to limit China's rise. Failure to do so would erode the relative advantage the US has in controlling higher levels of productive forces and the resulting monopoly privileges that control entails. There is almost complete alignment amongst the US state actors to continue to manage decoupling from China (despite the near impossibility of fully re-modernising US productive forces domestically) and to advance military preparations against China.

The February 2022 movement of Russian troops into Ukraine—a result of the continued violations of US assurances on the non-expansion of the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO) and the continuing civil war between Kyiv and Donbas—marked an explicit new phase in world military alignment for the US. In a series of rapid-fire moves, the US openly subordinated all the Global North countries and, in so doing, further subordinated the military apparatus of those states. It established itself as the open military hegemon of what is euphemistically called NATO+, which includes all but three members of the former Eastern Bloc. Those who attended the 2023 NATO summit in Vilnius, Lithuania, as a member or observer—including Australia, New Zealand, Japan, and the Republic of Korea—are de facto members of NATO+. Only Israel (excused from attendance for political expediency) and a few smaller countries of the Global North did not attend.

Beginning in October 2023, Israel began a campaign of displacement, ethnic cleansing, collective punishment, and genocide of Palestinians with the full and shameless support of the United States government. The developments in Ukraine followed by the recent escalations in Gaza are significant markers reflecting that there has been a qualitative change within the imperialist system. The US has now completed its economic, political, and military subordination of all the other imperialist countries. This has consolidated an integrated, militarily focused imperialist bloc. It aims to maintain a grip on the Global South as a whole and has turned its attention to dominating Eurasia, the last area of the world that has escaped its control.

It is not a matter of exaggeration to say that the Global North has declared a state of open hostility and war on any section of the Global South that does not comply with the policies of the Global North. This is seen in the [joint declara-](#)

[tion](#) on EU-NATO Cooperation published on 9 January 2023: “We will further mobilise the combined set of instruments at our disposal, *be they political, economic, or military*, to pursue our common objectives to the benefit of *our* one billion citizens.”⁵

The Palestinian people in Gaza are certainly feeling the palpable barbarity of NATO+ and the forced ‘mass consensus’ of which the Global North is capable. As Palestinian liberation leader Leila Khaled put it recently: We know that they speak about terrorism, but they are the heroes of terrorism. The imperialist force everywhere in the world, in Iraq, in Syria, in different countries... are preparing to attack China. All of what they say about terrorism turns to be about them. People have the right to resist with all means to it, including the armed struggle. This is in the Charter of the United Nations. So, they are violating the rights of people for resistance because it's their right to restore their freedom. And this is, and I say it always, a fundamental law: where there is repression, there is resistance. People will not live under occupation and repression. History taught us that when people resist, they can keep their dignity and their land.⁶

Imperialism has begun its transformation to a new stage: Hyper-Imperialism.⁷ This is imperialism conducted in an exaggerated and kinetic way, whilst also subject to the constraints that the declining empire has foisted on itself. The spasmodic quality of its exertion is felt by the millions of Congolese, Palestinians, Somalis, Syrians, and Yemenis living under US militarism, whose heads instinctively jerk for cover at sudden sounds.

Yet, this is not the full-blooded march across the globe that the Cold War initiated, fought in proxy battles that were followed by economic imperialism through the World Bank and other development institutions. It is the imperialism of a drowning billionaire who firmly believes he ought to be back on his yacht. It flexes the muscles of power that are still strong—the military. However, absent productive power and knowing that financial power is at a tipping point, the full suite of imperial technologies of control that the US once had is no longer at its disposal. It, therefore, channels its efforts through the mechanisms it has most at hand: culture (the control of truth) and war.

The tactics of Hyper-Imperialism are shaped partly by the modernisation of hybrid warfare, which includes lawfare, hyper-sanctions, seizure of national reserves and assets, and other manners of non-military warfare. New technological tools of surveillance and targeted communication characterising the digital age are deployed to wage imperialist control of the battle of ideas. This has involved implementing more perverse and covert methods against the truth, such as the political imprisonment of WikiLeaks' publisher Julian Assange, who exposed numerous crimes against the Global South.⁸

The Global North is an integrated military, political, and economic bloc composed of 49 countries. These include the US, the UK, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, Israel, Japan, and secondary Western and Eastern European countries. In the military arena, Turkey (as a NATO member), the Republic of Korea and the

Philippines (de facto militarised colonies of the US) are included in our definition of the ‘US-led Military Bloc’, even though they are part of the Global South.

Over the last twenty years, the Global North has endured a significant relative economic decline, along with a political, social, and moral decline. Its false ‘moral’ claims of civil rights and ‘press freedom’ are now complete mockeries as they seek to make illegal the public (including online) support for Palestinian rights. This full-on support for the humiliation and destruction of the darker peoples of the world is reminiscent of past centuries, exposing what can be described as collective ‘white fragility’.

The Global South countries comprise former colonies and semi-colonies, a few non-European independent states, and current and former socialist projects. The struggles for national liberation, independence, development, and total economic and political sovereignty still need to be completed for most of the Global South.

Despite the limitations of the terminology, we will use the term ‘Global North’ and occasionally ‘the West’ (an often-used hollow phrase) interchangeably with the more accurate term of the ‘US-Led Imperialist Camp’. We will analyse the Global North in four ‘Rings’. The rest of the world is currently known as the ‘Global South’, much of it was previously called the ‘Third World’. We will analyse the Global South in six ‘Groupings’ that are determined by the relative degree to which a country is a target of regime change and the role its government plays in publicly advancing international, anti-imperialist stances. The Global North is engaged in much higher levels of generalised conflict with the rest of the world, the Global South.

Tricontinental: Institute for Social Research is an international institute guided by popular movements and organisations. We seek to build a bridge between academic production and political and social movements in order to promote critical thinking and stimulate debates and research with an emancipatory perspective that serves the people’s aspirations.

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The Student Intifada Links Racism, Mistreatment of Indigenous People, Policing, Global Warming, Anti-Colonial Struggles Around the World, Capitalism, and Imperialism

GARY OLSON

Those protesters have started a fire that’s going to burn straight through the whole system.

— Shahid Bolsen

Palestine has become the icon of freedom for the people of the world.

— Author Unknown

The protest movements—which have spread around the globe—are not built around the single issue of the apartheid state of Israel or its genocide against Palestinians. They are built around an awareness that the old-world order, the one of settler-colonialism, western imperialism, and militarism used by the countries of the Global North to dominate the Global South, must end. They decry the hoarding of natural resources and wealth by industrial nations in a world of diminishing returns. These protests are built around a vision, and the commitment to it, that will make this movement not only hard to defeat but presages a wider struggle beyond genocide in Gaza.

— Chris Hedges

The national security state is alarmed by recent student protests. Alex Karp, ardent Zionist and CEO of Palantir, an advanced data mining company whose customers include the CIA, NSA, FBI, and Israel, recently shared this fear: “We think these things that are happening across college campuses are a sideshow. No, they are the show. If we lose the intellectual debate, we will be unable to deploy the army in the West, ever.”

We are indebted to Max Blumenthal at The Grayzone for interpreting the elite’s penultimate nightmare as follows: If this model spreads and succeeds, the U.S. will not be able to maintain its imperial army and 800 bases around the world and the U.S. will begin to resemble a normal country. This, of course, is impermissible because empathy-devoid psychopaths like Karp and the rest of the parasitic elite would no longer be the recipients of corporate welfare at the expense of the rest of us. The students, and allies who agree with their demands, are an existential threat to the system because they’re hitting the third rail.

Our ideological gatekeepers expend prodigious amounts of time and resources to create empathy-deficient cultural programming that dampens any public empathic engagement. As suggested above, the parasitic elite fear an empathy epidemic. However, they’ve been overwhelmed by 24/7 images from Gaza and the campus protests. We see that the dominant cultural narrative is not hermetically sealed from

efforts to produce counter-narratives that connect to other struggles. For example, at M.I.T., students stress that their Gaza protest is not a separate struggle but one struggle synchronizing resistance movements against white supremacy, patriarchy, and issues involving Haiti, Cuba, Puerto Rico, and the exploitation of resources in Congo. (Austin Cole, Black Agenda Radio, 5/24/24). Interviews with protesters across the country reveal that students have done their due diligence and frequently salted their explanations with “academic terms like intersectionality, colonialism, and imperialism, all to make the case that the plight of Palestinians is the result of global power structures that thrive on bias and oppression.”

Jones, a first-year student at Emory University in Atlanta, linked her activism to the civil rights movement in which her family had participated. “The only thing missing was the dogs and the water, she said. Another student, Katie Rueff a first-year student at Cornell, linked it to climate justice, saying “It’s rooted in the same struggles of imperialism, capitalism — things like that. I think that’s very true of this conflict, of the genocide in Palestine.” (*The New York Times*, 5/2/24)

At Emory, protesters occupying the quad chanted “Free Palestine,” along with opposing the Atlanta Public Training Facility or “Cop City,” an enormous \$90 billion, 318-acre site just outside Atlanta. It’s on land stolen from the Muscogees while Israel’s “Little Cop City” is on land in the Negev stolen from the Palestinians. Emory students see a considerable overlap between greater justice in policing and what’s happening in Gaza as hundreds of police trainees are sent from the U.S. to Israel to train with their counterparts under the guise of “homeland security.” Israel’s military connection to Atlanta is emblematic of the partnership between the two countries in approaching unrest. Much of the cost of Cop City is being footed by corporations like Delta, Amazon, Wells Fargo, Waffle House, J.P. Morgan, UPS, and Chick-fil-A.

Further, revealing the widespread complicity of university research for the Pentagon is one reason for the swift and harsh response to the protests as this is something that can’t be negotiated away under the existing system. For example, in 2024, Carnegie Mellon University in Pittsburgh had received more than \$2.8 billion for research from the Pentagon since 2008, only the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) and Johns Hopkins University have received more, at \$18 billion and \$15 billion. MIT also does research for the Israeli Ministry of Defense, a fact not lost on protesters there.

One additional damning truth, and one that bears explication in the future, is the US empire manager’s long-term project for imperial primacy in the region. That is, the tripartite security pact of the U.S., Saudi Arabia, and Israel was temporarily derailed by Hamas’ October 7 resistance attack and Israel’s response. This grand bargain or “deal of the century,” a phrase coined by Egypt’s president Abdul Fatah al-Sisi, would entail Riyadh normalizing relations with Israel. In turn, the U.S. would turn on the spigot of offensive weapons heading to the Kingdom—a major boon to the American war industry. Israeli officials estimate an eventual benefit of trade with Saudi Arabia amounting to \$45 billion. For now, “Plan B” is that Israel be excluded from the pact until Gaza is resolved. If this arrangement occurs, it will mean more injustice for the Palestinians, including stepped-up Zionist violence in the

West Bank, and because the deal is so unpopular with the “street Arabs,” even more oppression of people under autocratic US allies in the region.

The 1960s and 1970s witnessed powerful movements centered around racism and the Vietnam War. Many of us older folks were radicalized by this period, and it has defined our lives ever since. However, over time, powerful elites were able to reimagine these events as one-offs, in part, because we treated them as such and failed to identify them as endemic to the system of capitalism itself, and required dismantling the empire.

Ted Morgan, a scholar of the 1960s social movements, told me via an e-mail that “1960s activism was largely wiped out by a combination of distorted media coverage, a potent right-wing, corporate backlash, and a cooptive narcissistic culture of consumption and entertainment. In 1968, the US war helped to trigger the global protest movement—well documented in Tariq Ali’s *1968*. However, 1968 was also the turning point for the rise of neoliberalism and the New Right in US politics. The neoliberal order was resisted again and again against the U.S. role in Central America, the nuclear arms race, the U.S. wars in Iraq and Afghanistan, the climate crisis, global warming, and ecocide, and by the Occupy Movement and Black Lives Matter. However, it wasn’t until the rising global movement against the genocidal Israeli attack on Gaza and the West Bank—and US complicity in that assault—that the potential of 1968 has been revived.” (For more, see, Edward P. Morgan, *What Really Happened in the 1960s*, University of Kansas Press, 2011).

When the “student intifada” of campus encampments sprang up, we could say, along with The Electric Intifada’s Susan Abulhawa, “This time is different from the uprisings of the 1960s and 1970s. There is a new sense of global interconnection, an emerging class consciousness, and foundational political analyses predicated on post-colonial studies and intersectionality.”

We also know that members of Generation Z (18–29) are far more distrustful of the media than older adults and according to Gallup/Knight, they pay close attention to an outlet’s transparency of facts and research. Students have been informed by information outside of mainstream sources like *The New York Times*, *Washington Post*, and CNN, which act as the U.S. government’s echo chamber. Many have turned to Al Jazeera which has 1.0 million followers on TikTok and 4.6 million on Instagram. Cameron Jones, an organizer with Jewish Voices for Peace at Columbia University, told *The New York Times* “There’s a fair amount of misinformation media and just a clear bias when it comes to the Palestinian issue.” And Hussein Irish of the Arab States Institute in Washington, added that “There’s a third worldish, anti-imperialist point of view, that many college kids have adopted.”

An encouraging sign for this summer and evidence that encampments are not the end, is the Coalition to March on the DNC in Chicago which already has 76 organizations on board and looks to have 200+ by August. Gaza is the catalyst bringing together immigrants, women, LGBT, union reps, and opponents of police repression. This helps to cement the connection between domestic and international affairs.

As suggested earlier, it’s this growing capacity of students, and allies who agree with their demands, to begin connecting the dots—and sharing that insight with clear, concise language—that constitutes the real fear of the ruling class. It explains

their hysterical response like attempts to ban TikTok, police state crackdowns, rending of the First Amendment, demonization of anti-war protesters, blaming “outside agitators,” and the media’s weaponizing of antisemitism.

Given the above, the potential for identifying with “the other” has never been so promising. If combined with critical thinking, patience, ingenuity in communication, and Gramsci’s “optimism of the will”, we dare to say that the possibility of transforming Gaza into a broader class struggle lies before us for the taking.

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A pro-Palestinian protest encampment by students at the University of Manitoba, Canada. (Trevor Brine/CBC)

Hunger Strikes and the Commodification of Student Movements for Palestine

FATIMA KHALLADI

“Without revolutionary theory, there cannot be revolutionary movements” —Lenin.

On February 19, students at McGill University, in collaboration with Students for Justice in Palestine (SJP McGill), began a hunger strike demanding the university to divest all 74+ million dollars of investments in companies funding or involved in Israel as well as ending academic relations with Israeli institutions in historic Palestine. The hunger strike started with indefinite hunger strikers and rotational hunger strikers. The former was committed to striking for as long as possible, while the latter would commit to a defined time, such as 3–6 days, to show support for the indefinite hunger strikers and to further pressure the university by encouraging more students to join the action, fully understanding that hunger striking is a form of protest with serious [physical and mental consequences](#) for the participants.

The first indefinite hunger strike started on February 19 and lasted 34 days before the first person was hospitalized. The second student lasted 36 days before being hospitalized. The last student lasted 40 days. The hunger strikes lasted 76 days. The McGill administration met with the strikers once on day 55. In that meeting, the McGill administration refused to explain why as a publicly funded institution, McGill is investing in a state committing genocide. Angela Campbell, a “human rights lawyer” and McGill associate provost of equity and academic policies, sat there looking at Chadi, the second hospitalized student, in full view of the Zoom call, and refused to acknowledge their presence while stating that McGill’s association with Zionist institutions is a matter of academic freedom. Even with thousands of supporters in the community, including 1200 faculty and staff members, the hunger strike could not get the McGill administration to budge on the issue of divestment.

“McGill and Concordia don’t care at all if students live or die,” said Zulfaqar, a student community activist. “That is their level of detachment from the issues at hand and it is beyond disgraceful.”

“It has been a crushing experience to witness and live the cruelty and inhumanity of the McGill administration,” says Rania, the first hospitalized hunger striker. “My love and yearning for learning and higher education have been pulverized because the institutions that are responsible for educating us have white supremacist, colonial, and capitalist values entrenched at their core. McGill has now watched three of their students be hospitalized, me included, after starving ourselves for more than 30 days in protest of the university’s bloodied investments and academic ties to Israel and Zionism. It was evident that McGill places genocide-stained money and power like the colonial institution it always has been over the well-being of their students as well as the larger community.”

The hunger strike aimed to bring a focus on the suffering that McGill was contributing to in Palestine, including the weaponization of starvation affecting

2.2 million Gazans. Unsurprisingly, McGill administrators showed as much concern about the suffering of ordinary Palestinians as they did about the students. “It is disgraceful to see McGill continue to disregard the wellbeing of their students and human life in general,” says Ana, the hunger strike’s financial analyst.

The administration, however, was not the only obstacle encountered by the student hunger strikers. Liberal Palestinian groups on campus also often opposed both the hunger strikes as a form of protest and the more radical demands associated with them. The student hunger strikers belong to an independent group of students who nevertheless had partnered with and emerged out of the SJP McGill, a leftist intersectional Palestinian-led group with a horizontal structure. The SJP McGill was formed in October 2023 in response to the Palestinian students’ need for a space to organize after they were excluded from the existing Palestine organizing group on campus, Solidarity for Palestinian Human Rights McGill (SPHR McGill). A disagreement ensued over issues related to questions concerning organizational hierarchy, policy, and intersectionality of the Palestinian liberation struggle with struggles for the liberation of all peoples.

Despite movement issues, the hunger strike had its successes. “It generated local, national, and international attention and pressure on McGill concerning its investments in Israel and support of Zionist ideology” reflects Kit, of Hunger Strike Care Team. “An institution that paints itself as elite and a leader on the international stage was exposed for the genocidal institution that it has always been by *The Guardian* and *Middle East Eye*.” The McGill hunger strikers had “sparked their movement before encampments of students across the globe” demanding McGill University “divest from Israel-linked firms.” “Another success,” Kit states, “is that it fortified mutual aid and care networks necessary for furthering a sustainable movement.” The McGill hunger strikes inspired many other student-led hunger strikes across Turtle Island, one of which was the USF hunger strike with direct participation by McGill activists.

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Student movements have historically played a major role in struggles for social justice and change, such as in ending the system of apartheid in South Africa, challenging the Jim Crow laws in the US, the Arab revolts in West Asia, and the Palestinian struggles for self-determination and justice. The power of student movements within the Palestinian struggle can not be overstated. Concerning the latter struggle, for example, [it was](#) “[t]he political activism of Palestinian students in Cairo [that] laid the basis for establishing Fatah (Palestinian National Liberation Movement). Yasser Arafat and Abu Iyad were among the students who won elections in the Palestinian Student Union in Cairo as early as 1952.”

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In April, students at Columbia University in the US started an encampment on school grounds to pressure the university to divest from companies investing in Israel as it carries out a genocide in Gaza. Students at Columbia were met with heavy police suppression, which only made the encampments larger. Encampments started popping up nationwide and in Canada, both in solidarity with the students at Columbia and to pressure their respective universities to divest from Israel.

Students in most universities in Canada were planning for a nationwide movement before the establishment of Columbia’s encampment. In many universities, they wanted to take their time and plan a sustainable encampment while in others, especially in Canada’s larger and more prestigious universities such as McGill, they wanted to “hop on the US momentum,” which often resulted in ill-planned encampments.

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Less noticed in public conversations about the student encampments has been the large presence of the indigenous peoples of Turtle Island in Canada. The Mohawk people in Tiohtià’ke (Montreal), the indigenous nations whose land we occupy, were heavily involved in the movement. The Mohawk Mothers are currently in a lengthy legal battle with McGill University over dead bodies found under the Royal Victoria Hospital on McGill’s campus. These are deaths linked to the US-funded MK-Ultra experiments of the 1960s, most of which happened at McGill University. The Iroquois nations graciously permitted students to set up encampments on their lands so long as they followed Iroquois laws and treated the land and the people respectfully.

This permission was rescinded three weeks later after the camp pushed out most leftist students and adopted hierarchical decision-making systems in place of more inclusive democratic procedures involving all participants. This is a clear example of a problem plaguing many encampments in Canada: the desire for power and control by some people at the expense of grassroots democratic procedures.

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There is also a commodification-of-popular-movements problem that requires our urgent attention. And the movement in solidarity with the Palestinian struggle for self-determination and justice is no exception. Under capitalism, commodifying a movement is one of the most effective ways of destroying it. Turn it from a legitimate intellectual and material cause to a bunch of slogans, t-shirts, and performative actions. The movement becomes devoid of roots, principles, and thought. We saw this happen to the Black Lives Matter movement, when corporations started posting black squares, and white people who have always benefited from white supremacy washed their hands free of guilt by going to a protest or posting a video rather than genuinely understanding their part in the oppression. We need to remain vigilant and prevent this from happening to the Palestine solidarity movements. Troubling signs are emerging. “A liberal fest, calling cops friends, idolizing identity politics, and allowing white Jewish allies to take precedence over actual Palestinians,” says Layla, a student activist at another university in Ontario, pointing to emerging troubling developments.

“Without revolutionary theory, there cannot be revolutionary movements,” said Lenin. Liberal groups are co-opting more radical movements for justice in Palestine. Solidarity encampments have begun slowly to take Oslo accord-type deals for partial divestment or simply for amnesty for the students involved. Intersectionality and collective liberation mean less to people who merely want to hop on a trend. At McGill, where students had a record-breaking referendum in support of divestment that led the university to threaten to defund the student union, a 76-day hunger strike was crushed by groups like SPHR and the Palestinian Youth Movement (PYM). They took the work and efforts of countless students and degraded them to meaning-

less action. “It’s very disheartening to see non-profits and normalizing NGOs capitalize on student encampments and be pulling the strings. How can the students be confident that their demands will be met?” says Layla. When walking through the camp, you often genuinely forget what the encampment was for.

Without a deeper theoretical grounding and in the absence of an organizing tradition to reflect and build on, as US students can with their history of the civil rights movement, Canadian student movements are more easily subjected to cooptation and other machinations that dilute their energies. Hunger Strikers now increasingly stand alone in a sea of meek colonial normalizers, facing so many hurdles, including administrative recalcitrance in their university. The co-opting of the movement creates debilitating divisions too. “This encampment claims it is for Palestinians and liberation for all, but it pushes away Palestinians who have other ideas, doxes them, and allows bigotry to run on-site unchecked,” says Layla. It allows movement opportunists to assume positions of power, many of whom come from wealthier Gulf-Arab families.

People sometimes say that Palestine has divided the left; rather, it has defined the left. We know now the who is who of the participants and what happens when you let opportunists take power organizationally. The leftist Palestinians and those with intersectional identities have been pushed aside by the more mainstream activists with a more conventional version of “resistance.”

The purging of the leftist students from McGill’s camp, however, resulted in the creation of an encampment at UQAM, a French university in Montreal. This encampment was much more militant and achieved full divestment and an end to all ties with Israel within three weeks of its formation notwithstanding multiple clashes with police and other authorities.

“While positive, I believe the student encampments have lost sight of their political goals and the replication of class dynamics seems ever-present,” says Lia, a community activist in Montreal. “As we saw Cal Poly Humboldt, a working-class polytechnic university, took the lead on what was regarded as more militant strategies, a similar analysis can perhaps be made in Montreal where the elite university McGill seems to have opted for more symbolic strategies. The formation of the UQAM encampment, a university where more socio-economic marginalization is present, was born out of frustration with this.”

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In the final analysis, what is most needed if the Palestinian solidarity movements are to avoid the pitfalls of cooptation and marginalization is theoretical groundedness, intersectional practices, and liberatory education. Ironically, we are talking about a student movement in an elite university that fails to acknowledge a deeply radical approach to Palestine activism and education.

A sure way to marginalize radical visions of liberation in movement-building is to isolate them from other struggles. The struggle for justice in Palestine is integrally connected with anti-capitalist, anti-racist, anti-patriarchal, and anti-imperialist struggles. In their absence, we are bound to repeat the same debilitating issues repeatedly. We must acknowledge race, gender, class, ethnicity, and nationality when

entering spaces like an encampment. We cannot play a Macklemore song about student encampments at the encampments while he does concerts in the UAE, which is participating in a genocide in Sudan. We must all learn as we act. Often in this journey of Palestinian advocacy, my comrades and I have been told that we are creating division. The fact is that we are divided. We work alone rather than fall in line under a false flag.

Fatima Khalladi is a Palestinian-Tunisian Neuroscience and Cognitive Science student at McGill University. She was born and raised in Ontario, Canada, and has been an activist for Palestine and other social issues since she was a child. Since October 7, 2023, she has lost many family members in Gaza, which led her to found SJP McGill. She participated in a hunger strike to pressure her university to divest from Israel.



Sabaaneh/MiddleEastMonitor

How Patriarchal Pronatalism Dominates the Conversation About the Human Future

NANDITA BAJAJ

Governments worldwide are in a race to see which one can encourage the most women to have the most babies. Hungary is slashing income tax for women with four or more children. Russia is offering women with 10 or more children a “Mother-Heroine” award. Greece, Italy, and South Korea are bribing women with attractive baby bonuses. China has instituted a three-child policy. Iran has outlawed free contraceptives and vasectomies. Japan has joined forces with the fertility industry to infiltrate schools to promote early childbearing. A leading UK demographer has proposed taxing the childless. Religious myths are preventing African men from getting vasectomies. A eugenics-inspired Natal conference just took place in the U.S., a nation leading the way in taking away reproductive rights.

The push for more babies to increase our numbers is hardly a new phenomenon. Longstanding forces of reproductive control have always favored population growth. These go back 5,000 years to the institutionalized male domination and patriarchy that emerged upon the rise of early states and empires centered in cities. Societies at the vanguard of civilization had two main goals: population expansion and seizure of resources. These were realized by coercing women to have as many children as possible and by pressuring men to become soldiers. Because of the dangers of both childbirth and war, birthing and soldiering had to be exalted and reinforced through social controls. To this day, pronatalism and militarism remain among patriarchy’s key features.

Its strength undiminished over the course of millennia, pronatalism serves powerful institutions of the state, the church, the military, and the economy by preaching that parenthood is an obligation, not a choice. Pronatalism runs so deep in our society, has become so pervasive, that to this day it colors the most important policy discussions and social norms.

As the Earth system groans under the burden of too many people consuming too much stuff, a new twist on this ubiquitous ideology—one that contemptuously sees women as mere procreative vessels—plays out on the global stage. While scientists warn that human numbers are a key driver of ecological and social crises, the subject of overpopulation gets short shrift by policymakers, think tanks, and even environmental groups. We are told that numbers don’t matter; what matters is solely the level of per capita consumption.

For example, when the revered Jane Goodall spoke about the harms of population growth, environmental journalist-cum-activist George Monbiot attacked her by insinuating that she was proposing the culling of people. Elsewhere he wrote, “It’s no coincidence that most of those who are obsessed with population growth are post-reproductive wealthy white men.”

I am a woman, born in India and now living in Canada, happily childfree as I near the end of my reproductive years. I am grateful to have a steady income, but I am not wealthy. Some might say I’m obsessed with overpopulation, though obsession isn’t the right term to describe a rational assessment of the role of population in the ecological degradation that makes humanity’s future precarious.

But Monbiot’s is just one example. Environmental journalist David Roberts acknowledges that population growth is a problem and then goes on to explain why “there’s much downside and not much upside to talking about population.” Katherine Hayhoe, chief scientist at The Nature Conservancy, an organization that has been accused of “promoting false climate solutions,” says in an interview, “As a climate scientist, I know that it’s not the number of people that matters. It’s how we live.” A formal statement by The Union of Concerned Scientists reads, “We’re sometimes asked ‘Isn’t population growth driving climate change?’ But that’s the wrong question—and it can lead to dangerous answers.”

Let’s unpack these statements, all of which fall into what political and social theorist Diana Coole has called the discourses of population denialism.

The first of these, “population shaming”, justifies silence about population by pointing to the excesses of “population control” movements of the past. And it is true that these coercive efforts deserve repudiation. Beginning in the 1970s, India forcibly sterilized millions of poor people (and was backed in this endeavor by some Western powers). That was a dark moment in a benighted time, which focused on decreasing population growth in the lower-income countries rather than on moderating dramatically higher per capita consumption in the high-income countries.

But it would be fallacious, and a disservice to the valiant history of family planning, to suppose all approaches to curbing population growth are destructive. During and following India’s reprehensible conduct, family planning programs in Thailand, Costa Rica, Iran, and elsewhere not only advanced greater personal and reproductive autonomy for girls and women, but also led to significantly lower fertility rates, decreases in poverty, and gains in environmental conservation.

We know from historical experience that slowing population growth requires upholding fundamental human rights: championing universal education, prohibiting child marriage, empowering females, improving access to family planning services, and, most of all, standing up to patriarchy and pronatalism.

This relates to another oft-used and largely-superseded discourse of population denialism that “development” or economic growth is required to spur declines in fertility, a claim that plays directly into the hands of pro-growth neoliberal interests. Research shows that declining fertility rates, however, are most closely associated with increasing use of modern contraception and are largely independent of changes in the economy.

Disproportionately focusing on reproductive control efforts in the recent past, as so many environmentalists do, entirely misses the millennia-old chokehold of compulsive pronatalism in driving population growth—which makes these environmentalists unwitting accomplices of pronatalist patriarchy.

Equally as offensive is that population denialism defies scientific evidence.

In its 2022 report, the IPCC makes abundantly clear that “globally, GDP per capita and population growth remained the strongest drivers of CO₂ emissions from fossil fuel combustion in the last decade.” In a 2024 survey conducted by The Guardian, leading IPCC scientists candidly discussed their decisions to have no or fewer children, citing as their main motivations the impact of overpopulation on climate change and the fear of bringing their potential children into a perilous world environment.

In 2017, over 15,000 scientists from 184 countries issued a warning that “we are jeopardizing our future by not reining in our intense but geographically and demographically uneven material consumption and by not perceiving continued rapid population growth as a primary driver behind many ecological and even societal threats.” Other [Scientists’ Warnings](#) have raised similar alarms.

In 2022, the UN Convention to Combat Desertification warned that “within the next few decades, 129 countries will experience an increase in drought—23 primarily due to population growth and 38 because of their interaction between climate change and population growth.”

In its 2022 report, the UN Department of Social and Economic Affairs warned that “rapid population growth makes it more difficult for low-income and lower-middle-income countries to afford the increase in public expenditures on a per capita basis that is needed to eradicate poverty, end hunger and malnutrition, and ensure universal access to health care, education and other essential services.”

It goes without saying that hyper-consumerism and affluence-seeking in rich countries have played an outsized role in these crises, yes. But to focus on consumerism alone misses the full complexity of the world problematique.

The global middle class is the fastest rising demographic group, with at least one billion people—88% from Asia—projected to join it this decade, totaling 5.3 billion middle-class consumers. And other poorer billions surely have the right to increase their standard of living. Given that we are already in an extreme state of ecological overshoot, in which we are consuming 75% percent more than Earth can regenerate, further growth in our population and economy can only come at the expense of biophysical Earth systems, which means increased peril to our collective future. Refusing to deal with the twin threats of population and consumption, both of which are at unsustainable levels, only accelerates the destruction of other life and puts us on a long-term trajectory of immiseration of billions of people.

Meanwhile, some politicians and pundits seem to believe the great threat to humankind is a shrinking economy driven by declining fertility rates and aging populations—that is, the threat is not too many people but too few. “Population decline”, as this is known—another tentacle of population denialism—is what is fueling the global trend of pushing women to pump out the babies.

Even amid declining fertility rates due to greater gender equality, global population is still growing by about 80 million people annually, just as in 1970, adding a projected 2.5 billion before the end of this century.

Observers of the panic about declining fertility rates, such as Nobel laureate Steven Chu, have suggested that we are caught in a “Ponzi scheme” of endless growth that is “based on having more young workers than older people.” This unsustainable and ecologically-destructive scheme, which relies on an ever-increasing population,

mostly serves the interests of tech billionaires, elites like Elon Musk, and the ideologies of far-right, religious, nationalist, and market fundamentalists.

Not only has population denialism among progressives emboldened the far-right to pursue its pronatalist agenda of rolling back reproductive rights, passing stricter divorce laws, and relaxing domestic violence laws, progressives are now joining the chorus of “baby-bust” alarmism.

Media outlets regularly platform growth-biased pieces: this in *The New York Times* by an author whose organization received \$10 million from Elon Musk for “fertility research”; this, this, and this in *The Washington Post* by contributors affiliated with the American Enterprise Institute, a right-wing think tank with a history of climate denial and whose funders include ExxonMobil and the Koch brothers; and this by Vox in their Future Perfect section, a billionaire-funded project embedded in the deeply controversial effective altruism philosophy.

More disturbingly, attempts to challenge pronatalism today are strategically conflated by these pro-growth actors with anti-natalism, baby hating, or misanthropy.

Meanwhile, the rights of children to be born into conditions conducive to their social, psychological, and material well-being are all but trampled as nations compete to pump out, by any means necessary, the next generation of worshippers, workers, consumers, taxpayers, soldiers, and of course, procreators. Warnings from leading authorities about dire, population-driven consequences for children in the form of climate change impacts and extreme poverty, among others, go unheeded.

The alarmism surrounding declining fertility rates is unfounded; it is a positive trend that represents greater reproductive choice, and one that we should accelerate. A smaller human population will immensely facilitate other transformations we need: mitigating climate change, conserving and rewilding ecosystems, making agriculture sustainable, and making communities more resilient and able to integrate more climate and war refugees.

Research shows that societies with smaller populations and aging demographics can prosper. Instead of coercing women to have more babies, we can adopt progressive policies that strengthen social safety nets, wisely reallocate resources, and see seniors as meaningful contributors to society rather than a growing burden on a shrinking pool of younger workers. We can shift the failed paradigm of endless growth and transition to an economy that respects the biophysical limits of our planet.

It’s time to reject “population shaming” that pretends to champion human rights while echoing pronatalist ideologies that treat women’s wombs as cogs in the growth machine. To defend the right of all to a livable future, we need to get off the growth treadmill, get past population denialism, and work for a future that has both fewer human beings and less consumption.

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Are EVs Truly the Greenest Form of Transportation?

DON FITZ

A friend recently told me of a new study showing that the “life cycle” of electric vehicles (EVs) causes fewer CO₂ emissions than gas-powered cars. This is important since research comparing greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions per mile have left out the enormous emissions associated with the complex mining, manufacturing and disposal phases of EVs. Is this recent announcement just more corporate bunk? Or, could it mean that EVs are truly a step toward a greener world?

And, is there a transportation alternative that avoids the pitfalls of both EVs and gas cars?

The article by Julian Spector and Dan McCarthy was highly touted as showing that EVs are “definitely cleaner than gas cars over their lifetime.” Citing research by BloombergNEF, it admitted that the battery production phase of EVs results in more carbon emissions than occurs with fossil fuel (FF) cars. It claimed that driving EVs (the use phase) is so much “cleaner” than gas cars that, overall, EVs are responsible for fewer GHGs. It further insisted that the production phase of EVs is getting cleaner all the time, meaning that it is “a slam-dunk” for the environment.

Ever since I began teaching Environmental Psychology at Washington University years ago, when EVs were barely on the horizon, I explained to students the sleight-of-hand that manufacturers made when claiming that newer FF cars emitted fewer GHGs than older models. How could it be that cars were getting “cleaner” while simultaneously GHGs from all cars were going up?

This occurs if the categories of cars being purchased changes. More and more SUVs were being sold and they emitted greater quantities of CO₂ than did sedans. Thus, sedans became “cleaner;” SUVs became “cleaner;” but the total quantity of CO₂ from cars went up. The same principle applies today with FF cars and EVs.

Ralph Nader, who gained notoriety from publishing *Unsafe at Any Speed* (1965), recently wrote of serious problems with EVs. These include high-voltage lithium-ion battery fires, disruption of electric power by storms, the scarcity of minerals required for manufacture, and serious difficulties with recycling their very heavy batteries,

Car categories also affect pollution from tiny tire particles. While tire manufacturers are slowly “moving to make-longer lasting tires,” the category of EVs presents a greater problem than gas cars.

When a FF car weighing 5,000 pounds is replaced by an EV version, the weight is 8,000 pounds. As weight goes up, tire duration goes way down. Due to their heavier weight, EVs get only 13,000 miles per tire instead of the expected 40,000 miles.

When the Rubber Hits the Road

Writing in *The Atlantic*, David Zipper probes deeply into the tire problem that Nader touched on. Tire toxins include rubber, petroleum, nylon, and steel, with many specks being so minuscule that they cannot be seen by the human eye. Their quantity of

6 million tons globally is likely growing due to the heavier weight of EVs. Smooth roads can actually be more harmful because they result in smaller particles that float further.

The weight of EVs increases health threats to humans and other living things. Tires could be the source of 28% of ocean microplastics. One study found that the chemical 6PPD (designed to lengthen tire life) caused Northwestern-coho-salmon populations to decline dramatically.

Low income neighborhoods next to highways have suffered elevated birth defects, kidney damage, and problems for respiratory and neurological systems. The extra weight of EVs render them more dangerous to bikers, pedestrians, and those in other cars.

One factor which makes EVs so attractive is their extra power. The power appears both for acceleration (“instant torque”) and “regenerative” braking. These increase tire friction, which releases more wear particles that poison.

Since transportation is a large portion of total energy used, EVs are an integral part of the drive to “electrify everything.” Canada is offering \$13 billion to help Volkswagen build a facility to manufacture EV batteries. The “1500 acres of prime agricultural land” that would be taken for that factory is merely a fraction of the amount of land required for expanding electrification of energy sources.

While we usually think of ways to obtain necessary minerals for electrical power from mining land, there is likely to be at least as destructive effects from deep sea mining. Thousands of feet at the bottom of the sea rest nodules, deposits, and crusts containing materials such as nickel, rare earths, and cobalt.

The deep sea mining process releases chemicals and heavy metals which disrupt marine life. Sediments from mining are typically dumped back into the sea “which can harm filter-feeding species like corals and sponges.” The bottom of deep oceans are devoid of light and sound and typically do not have disturbances that stir up sediment. Many organisms on seabeds evolved without ways to filter out clouds of dirt or respond to the shining lights or noises of machines searching for and extracting minerals. Effects on unknown species are, of course, unknown.

Environmental Disaster Manifests Social Disruption

It is no coincidence that the production of EVs is wrapped around some of the most loathsome social conflicts on Earth. Unlimited expansion of electrification requires obfuscating what lurks in its corners.

The giant of EV production is Tesla, the only non-union company among major US automakers. It recently fired Buffalo, NY, workers following plans to unionize. Its boss Elon Musk is likewise infamous for mass firings after acquiring Twitter. While Musk seeks to captain a tight economic ship when keeping workers in line, he has no trouble squandering millions to pilot ships into outer space.

Far from being tangential for the environment, these events establish the context of Musk’s most revealing statement, “We will coup whoever we want.” Bolivia has extremely rich deposits of lithium which can most efficiently be mined for EV batteries by extracting vast amounts of water from an already dry desert.

When Bolivian president Evo Morales sought deals that would bring more money to the poor of that country he was illegally removed from office in 2019. When

Musk scripted that infamous comment in July 2020, his company had long looked at Bolivia with an eye hungry for lower lithium prices.

Even more distressing are the horrors that confront cobalt workers, as documented by Siddharth Kara's *Cobalt Red: How the Blood of the Congo Powers Our Lives* (2023). Almost 75% of cobalt is currently mined in the DRC by being "dug by 'artisanal miners', namely desperately poor people, including many children, for pennies a day."

In 2023, flooding and ensuing armed violence forced a half a million Congolese from their homes. Corporate media was not exactly absorbed with the story. As Secretary General of the Norwegian Refugee Council Jan Egeland told Amy Goodman on Democracy Now! "The Congo is not ignored by those who want to extract the riches of that place. It's ignored by the rest of the world who would want to come to the relief of the children and families of the Congo."

These practices portend things to come. As mining expands to the far corners on Earth, minerals required for solar panels, wind mills and EVs will become increasingly difficult to find and, like fossil fuel, will have decreasing yields. Corporations will increasingly treat indigenous communities as obstacles to be shoved aside and their politicians will increasingly comply "just to deal with the energy crisis we have right now."

When dollar costs of manufacturing cars are reported, some of these factors might not make their way to corporate spreadsheets: Legal donations to elect favorable politicians;

- Illegal bribes for politicians;
- Propaganda telling affected communities that there will be no serious environmental consequences from mining and manufacturing;
- Lawsuits from communities that suffer serious environmental consequences;
- Police and military personnel and equipment costs to put down opposition;
- Funeral costs for those killed by police and military.

Since EV supply chains require such a vast number of different minerals, these costs could well exceed those for FF cars.

The Only Green Form of Transportation Is ...

In reality, neither gas cars nor EVs sport the greenest transportation. The green alternative has been known for decades. Actually, for centuries or millennia. Just google the phrase "walkable communities" and you will find thousands of articles exploring how people can live better with parks, restaurants, stores, post offices, barber shops, schools, clinics, etc. within walkable distances.

Unfortunately, if discussions of transportation even mention "walkable communities" it is a throw-away phrase to be ignored after giving it lip service. The debate over EVs vs. gas cars is an enormous diversion from grappling with genuine issues that confront efforts to reduce transportation impacts: How do we transform existing neighborhoods into walkable/cycleable ones while including the very young, very old, and very sick?

- How do we maximize closeness to work while minimizing difficulties with moving?

- What would be the most reasonable ration of transportation miles per person via bus, train, and air?

Questions such as these show appreciation of this truism: The only green transportation is less transportation. We may take buses or trains for some trips and cars for special trips but green transportation has the goal of minimizing trips that cannot be made by walking or cycling (or golf-carting for those with physical limitations).

These concepts are central to the broader environmental question: How do we improve the quality of life of all people while treading more softly on the Earth? The corporate view of "environmentalism" is the exact opposite. Corporations exist in order to expand profits, which means expanding production, which requires convincing people to crave flashy things they do not need.

EVs epitomize the mindset of conspicuous consumption. As General Motors CEO Mary Barra quipped: "Once you've experienced an [electric vehicle] and all it has to offer—the torque, handling, performance, capability—you're in." If the glorification of crass consumerism by corporate executives is repulsive, its regurgitation by "environmentalists" is obscene.

Those who adopt the corporate mentality have their own set of questions:

- Why build a home with *passivhaus* design when you can cover the top of a neighboring mountain with wind turbines?
- Wouldn't it be a waste of effort to require new homes to be built to *passivhaus* standards when the tops of a mountain range could be clearcut for cheap, clean energy from an expanding wind turbine company?
- Why pass legislation to enhance walkable communities when EVs run so quietly and can zoom from 0 to 60 mph in less than four seconds?
- Why would those people badmouth EVs when buying one gives me warm fuzzy feelings that I have done all that I need to do for the environment?

EVs are hardly the only commodity that saddle humanity and the Earth with negative effects. At the same time that cars have increased in size and ostentation, home building has marched in step to the tune of pointless growth. As Canadian author Eves Engler observes, it's "past time to shift away from the private car and resource intensive sprawl towards walkable, bikeable, and transit-oriented living spaces ... automotive infrastructure underpins a massive growth in house sizes, which consume more wood, cement, glass pipe, etc.

The drive toward "more stuff" is not limited to larger stuff. It also means stuff that falls apart or goes out of style quicker. You may have noticed a shorter life-use span for everything from clothes to electric coffee pots along with the increasing inability to repair consumer products.

Those in Bolivia and the Congo who have direct experience with Western greed for power are not alone. For people throughout the world who suffer from fossil fuel colonialism, electrification of energy is not the end-all-be-all of a "just transition" to a more humane economy. Electrification is already becoming electric colonialism.

The deep green question regarding EVs is: "Should there be an EV for every adult on Earth?" If the answer is "yes," then EVs could be even more destructive than FF cars because of the vast amount of habitat required for mineral extraction as well as the expanded use of FFs that would be required to produce them. If the answer

is “no” then applauding EVs manufactured for only the rich world is the most crass form of colonialism imaginable.

Imaginary Numbers and Imagining True Effects

The electrification of energy should go global only if it is by and for those where the transition occurs. The means self-determination of energy sources that are consistent with people’s culture, preserve the land, water, and air where they live, and do not sacrifice these on the alter of corporate profit.

Infinite economic growth is antithetical to cultural and environmental preservation. Tunnel-visioning on the very real threat of climate change has lured many an environmentalist into the trap of “green growth” and away from the pursuit of conservation.

As Stan Cox points out, “economic growth has never been achieved over large geographical areas for extended time periods without having serious environmental impacts.” He explains that even a 2% growth rate cannot be sustained “without excessive resource extraction and greenhouse-gas emissions.”

Keeping these nuances in minds shines light on the claim that the life cycle of EVs has fewer CO₂ emissions than gas cars. A fact that is superficially true can be rendered ambiguous or false when taking its context into account.

A more complete context for cars would go beyond “life cycle” and incorporate its “Total Life Effects” (TLE), which would include factors which might only be imagined. The idea of imaginary values has stuck with me ever since taking high school algebra and studying little “i,” the square root of -1, or -1^{1/2}.

A complex number is expressed as: $a + i * b$, where $a =$ a real number and $b =$ the multiple for the imaginary number. “i” has become a serious line of study of abstract math. (Ironically, a field which finds “i” particularly useful is electricity.)

Since many enormous environmental effects are incalculable, big “I” could be included to imagine them. It is difficult to assess total environmental effects of the extinction of a species on its ecosystem. How would anyone estimate financial effects of the collapse of an ecosystem on near and far ecosystems? Who could possibly calculate the effects of an underwater holocaust of unknown species brought on by deep sea mining for minerals essential for EVs?

Thus, TLE would be expressed as a complex number with big I being Incalculable effects and Σ being their total effect: $TLE = \$ + \Sigma I$

All hitherto formulas for calculating environmental effects of manufacturing and mining are invalid and can become valid only by including big “I”s, that is, all potential effects on all species, including human cultures. In other words, those who who pretend that infinite expansion of electricity has no effect and leave big “I” out of their calculations — just as those who dismiss little “i” — suffer from a profound deficit in imagination.

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Editors’ Note: We are following the commune movement in Venezuela. Readers can refer to an excerpt from Chris Gilbert’s book Commune or Nothing! in the previous issue of Left Turn. We think that revitalizing the commune ought to be at the heart of socialist reconstruction in the present century. It represents the most effective response to the existential challenge facing humanity: how to avoid planetary ruination and build truly democratic, sustainable, and egalitarian societies.

In the following two pieces, the authors discuss more recent developments in the commune movement.

Building the New with the Old Still Standing: A Conversation with Lana Vielma

A young Venezuelan communard talks about El Maizal Commune’s present and future.

CHRIS GILBERT & CIRA PASCUAL MARQUINA

Lana Vielma is a young cadre at the flagship El Maizal Commune on the border of Lara and Portuguesa states. The daughter of a schoolteacher from the nearby town La Miel, Vielma began to work with El Maizal at the age of 15. Today, six years later, she serves as the communications director of the Simón Planas municipality, which comprises El Maizal and 12 other communes. Beyond her official role, Vielma is also an artist and filmmaker.

At age 21, you’ve already spent six years with El Maizal Commune. Could you share the story of how you became involved in the project and what drew you to this commune?

If it were not for the commune, I would have locked myself in at home and grown more and more frustrated with society... I think I would actually be angry! The world’s challenges are many, and more so for my generation, which yearns for freedom but is met with so many systemic injustices.

The commune touched me like a magic wand. It offered me a new worldview and gave me a life purpose—and that’s nothing short of magic. In the commune we learn from each other and solve problems collectively; we support one another because we have a common vision of the world. In short, we create a space in the commune that places human beings in the center.

As a young woman, the commune became my lifeline and changed me forever. The allure of flashy but most often unattainable perks that capitalism puts before young people doesn’t really point to a fulfilling life. That’s why the Communard Youth is so important: the commune is the only way for young people to have a meaningful existence and, at the same time, the commune needs young people.

Could you elaborate on the Communard Youth initiative?

Although we live in a territory that is home to the powerful El Maizal Commune, and people look up to it, the social media “magnet” projects the good life as based exclusively on having certain material things and leaves no room for the com-

munity. While we acknowledge the necessity to address material needs, we firmly believe that the spiritual and political dimensions of life must be reintegrated into the lives of our youth.

Compounding this, substance abuse is also a problem among some of the youth in Simón Planas, often contributing to family problems and crime. Some may be surprised when they hear this; they may think that in a rural context, substance abuse would not be a problem, but it is. Hence, it becomes imperative for the commune to present a viable and appealing model that addresses the needs of everyone, especially the youth.

The Communard Youth project stems from the need to draw the younger generations closer to the communal project. The commune is a platform like no other for political education, cultural activity, and debate.

You have a dual role as both a comunard and a member of the local government. How do you navigate this contested terrain?

Navigating this duality is complex. While the commune is our strategic objective, we believe that building resilient communes requires a creative approach. Ángel [Prado] became mayor of Simón Planas with one goal: fortifying the communes. But how to do this? As a comunard, he must demonstrate that his administration is not only efficient but also centered on the day-to-day well-being of the people, all this while promoting communal organization.

However, there are many challenges. The bureaucratic system is designed to reproduce itself while often neglecting people's genuine needs. For us, stepping into the local government meant disrupting its inertia, a task that has proven very challenging. However, we have taken steps toward what we call "communal government," fostering direct participation of the people in decision-making processes.

Little by little we are transforming the institutions and we have been able to solve many problems, from water access to healthcare. Still, institutions are not ends in themselves but means to ends. We still have many challenges, from the persistent bureaucratic logic to our own limitations, but we are carrying forward Chávez's project (the commune) and his method (working with the people).

We hope to continue opening communal pathways wherever we may be.

El Maizal is currently undergoing a transformation process, looking for ways to increase production and improve living conditions for the people who work here. How do you envision the commune's future, and what are the means of getting there?

Creating real, tangible conditions for a thriving society means creating economic conditions to support the everyday life of the comunards, while projecting a light into the future. Now, you might ask, is this really possible? Yes, we believe that it is! Humanity needs an alternative that will bring dignity and peace, but the transition has to happen with some comfort, even a touch of magnificence... In material terms, this means that people must have good conditions to work, study, and enjoy their leisure time.

At the same time, we must nurture political engagement at local, regional, national, and even global levels, which is what we know how to do best. But to do this

well, we have to have tangible arguments and real-life experiences; we have to be able to prove that our project works both politically and economically; we have to become a compelling example for others to follow.

You've used the metaphor of rebuilding a house to discuss the future of El Maizal Commune. Could you elaborate on this idea?

There is a philosophical idea that is very dear to me. If we live in a house but want a better one, we can't just tear it down and be left to the elements while we build a new one. That would be a bad idea. Our current dwelling, like it or not, is capitalist. That being so, we will have to build the new house from the inside and around the old house... until nothing is left of the old house!

What does this really mean? We have to build the new model gradually, forging a truly viable alternative, while we remain connected—for now—to the existing system. Then, once the new system is consolidated, we will tear down the old one.

In practical terms, what does this imply?

Here, in Simón Planas, a communal leader [Ángel Prado] is at the helm of the local administration. That being so, we may be tempted to focus solely on local politics, organizing an efficient administration from the Mayor's Office. However, this would fall short of our aspirations; it would be akin to "improving" the old capitalist structure with a new paint job.

Our idea extends far beyond creating a group of top administrators associated with the mayor's office and the commune who incrementally improve living conditions in Simón Planas. To consolidate the commune's hegemony, our project must present a substantive alternative, encompassing both political and economic dimensions that will truly attract and convince people.

Turning our attention to El Maizal, we are actively exploring new approaches to organize production so that we can satisfy the needs of the comunards that give their lives, day in and day out, to the project. The dual purpose is clear: offer a good life to the comunards while enhancing the viability of our model.

We know that this is a work in progress, but how do you envision the changes in El Maizal's economy?

Commercialization has always been a bottleneck for us, so we have to plan better. We must find mechanisms so that our production reaches the market without the obstacles put up by capitalist intermediaries. That is not easy, but it's a must.

We might create a new commercialization EPS [social production enterprise linked to the commune], and it is possible that we may be able to build a distribution and commercialization network with the Communard Union or in contact with the Ministry of Communes' Economic Circuits. However, one thing is evident: we need to plan better and must break the dependence on intermediaries.

Additionally, as I said before, we are thinking that the new economic model must generate conditions so that the most committed comunards can have more direct participation... All these considerations are crucial in building a new communal hegemony. If the commune doesn't yield tangible economic benefits, something has to give. Failing is not an option for us!

In all of this, communication is also important. Can you tell us about the work you do to report and produce content about El Maizal Commune and the Simón Planas Municipal government?

At El Maizal we are politically robust: people in Simón Planas township look up to Ángel Prado and El Maizal Commune. Nevertheless, it is crucial to recognize that not everyone perceives the commune as the ultimate solution or as a viable alternative.

Our capacity to communicate has grown over the years and now we can document every assembly in the territory of Simón Planas. We are also able to let people know that—from the mayor's office—we are doing many things, from repairing public lighting and roads to addressing health concerns and water problems to building houses and promoting sports and cultural events. However, while these efforts give us political cache, they fall short in relation to the communal project because they don't transform society as a whole.

That's why three years ago we inaugurated El Maizal's Yordanis Rodríguez "El Pelao" Communication School. Our objective is to connect young people to organizational processes and empower them so that communication is no longer the prerogative of reporters who will always favor "click-worthy" content.

It is imperative to highlight the significance of community-driven organizations, which should be reported by its actors. In this project, the role of youth is pivotal.

The Dialectics of Constituted and Communal Power: A Conversation with Ángel Prado

The main spokesperson of El Maizal Commune is trying to put institutional power at the service of the commune.

CHRIS GILBERT, CIRA PASCUAL MARQUINA

El Maizal Commune lies at the gateway to Venezuela's Llanos region, between the states of Lara and Portuguesa. It is one of the most consolidated communes in Venezuela with some 3,500 families living in its territory; vast expanses of land dedicated to corn and cattle; and a range of productive projects.

Ángel Prado is the commune's main spokesperson. Two years ago he won a difficult battle to become mayor of Simón Planas, which is the municipality comprising most of El Maizal along with 11 other communes. In this interview, Prado discusses his efforts in conjugating constituted power with the longstanding project of developing communal power.

Some of our readers are surely familiar with El Maizal, but could you present an overview of the commune?

El Maizal is a sum of experiences, practices, victories, and defeats. However, it is first and foremost a program and project bequeathed to us by Chávez, a program that shapes who we are and how we organize.

El Maizal embodies the communal way of life, which is based on seeking innovative methods and political approaches to create a better world. Of course, this new way of living is not defined by the logic of capital, but by putting what there is in common and ensuring dignity for all.

El Maizal brings together 27 communal councils and 2335 hectares of communal land. Beyond that, it has been able to link its work to that of the other communes in Simón Planas and with those in the Communard Union, which is a national organization made up of more than 50 communes. This is all very important because, as Chávez once said, communes can't remain isolated; if they do, they will be devoured by the hegemonic system, which is capitalist.

I think that El Maizal contributes significantly to our society and our class, because it adheres to Chávez's roadmap. That's why our commune—like many others—serves as a beacon, an example that inspires popular organizations around the country and even around the world.

Communes are more than just political entities; they represent an emerging economic model based on new social relations. Could you elaborate on this?

The battle against capitalism takes place on a large scale; it's about dismantling the existing norms, especially concerning property. That's why the collective ownership of property, the collectivization of work, and, of course, the communal distribution of surplus are so important.



Lana Vielma, a 21-year-old cadre who "discovered" El Maizal Commune when she was 15. (Venezuelanalysis)

Our end goal is to establish a culture of communal property countering the individualism promoted by capitalism. We aim to bring people together, organize within and for the community, and protect our means of production, all the while advancing toward industrialization and direct distribution. Ultimately, we aim to control the entire production cycle.

Currently, because we are primary producers, the surplus of our communal production is often captured by the capitalist market. This is a serious problem, which underscores the importance of communal industrialization.

What I am saying is not just true of El Maizal Commune: all communes need to industrialize. Failing to do so means having a survival economy on the periphery of the existing capitalist system.

After the fall of the Soviet Union, much of the global left turned its back on state power. Arguably, Chávez played a crucial role in repositioning the concept of “taking power” into the discourse of the left.

In Simón Planas, the communal movement sought a foothold in a space of constituted institutional power: the Mayor’s Office. It did so by supporting your successful campaign to become mayor. Why was it important to control that institution?

As Chavistas and communards, we aim to control existing resources and put them at the service of the people. In our case, this means taking control of the means of production and of the public institutions in our municipality.

El Maizal has a long history of communalizing vacant land and means of production, but more recently we succeeded in taking control of the Mayor’s Office by participating in the elections. Like Chávez, we don’t shy away from such contests.

Depending on who controls it, a local government can help or hinder progress toward communal goals and we work hard to do the former. Following Chávez, we believe in actively disputing power: seizing and placing it at the service of the people. Without Chávez’s ascent to political power, the commune wouldn’t have gained traction. His leadership was key to promoting the socialist project and rekindling discussions about the utopia we pursue.

Of course, it’s important that one not be devoured by power; instead, it should serve the people. In our country, when wielded in a revolutionary manner, state power can become a catalyst for advancing the commune.

Chávez repeatedly pointed out that Venezuela still has an essentially bourgeois state. Your objective as mayor is not to strengthen the bourgeois state but to create conditions for its dissolution. What are the dangers and opportunities, for you as a communard, in engaging in state-level politics?

Even when Chávez was alive, there was a campaign within the state to discredit the communal model, portraying it as outdated, unsuccessful, or inefficient. These notions persist. That is why we view our participation in the local government as an opportunity to show that communards can adeptly manage institutions.

Initially, we faced many challenges due to widespread skepticism. However, we have demonstrated that with political determination, adherence to principles, and a clear objective we can efficiently administer the apparatus of municipal government,

placing it at the service of the people. We see it as a tool, but the true catalyst for social transformation is the communal movement.

Nonetheless, there are potential pitfalls and dangers. If we were to interpret the Mayor’s Office as the focal point of politics, we would be failing as revolutionaries and Chavistas, since we would be abandoning what should be the core of our political and economic life: the commune.

Your administration as mayor of Simón Planas has proven highly effective. Municipal institutions have solved numerous problems with infrastructure, healthcare, and education. While these achievements are commendable, how do they contribute to the strategic goal of communal socialism?

From the Mayor’s Office, we have actively promoted debates, referendums, and collective decision-making processes. In other words, consultation is integral to our form of governance, which should be more and more communal every day.

For example, a year ago, we organized a referendum on participatory budgeting. The primary goal was to take down obsolete city ordinances that had been in place for over two decades, hindering our ability to budget, legislate, and govern collaboratively with the people. The referendum had several specific objectives: we wanted to reallocate funds once controlled by high-ranking officials to public works and we wanted to open crucial decision-making processes to the pueblo.

The referendum was a success. There was high participation and that paved the way for a new model of governance in which resources, information, and decision-making are no longer in the hands of a select few. Now the community participates in the political and economic direction of Simón Planas, thus strengthening communal organization.

Some of the comrades we have talked to here say that the “communal government” should eventually replace the Mayor’s Office. But what exactly is a “communal government” in that context?

Essentially, a communal government is the government by the people and for the people. It materializes when the community collectively decides what must be done and actively participates in its planning and execution. A communal government operates with autonomy, sovereignty, and the freedom to make decisions without institutional constraints.

Inspired by Chávez’s vision, our objective is to dissolve old institutions, such as the municipal government, and replace them with self-governed spaces fully committed to the communalization of society.

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It's Debatable: Talking Authentically about Tricky Topics

ROBERT JENSEN

"However unwillingly a person who has a strong opinion may admit the possibility that his opinion may be false, he ought to be moved by the consideration that, however true it may be, if it is not fully, frequently, and fearlessly discussed, it will be held as a dead dogma, not a living truth."

—John Stuart Mill, On Liberty

Introduction: Where I'm Coming From

To fulfill the obligations of democratic citizenship, we have to think freely, speak responsibly, and live authentically. Those are high standards, difficult to meet in any era. But particularly in a time marked by intense political partisanship—distorted by disembodied political engagement on social media—thinking freely, speaking responsibly, and living authentically can be a struggle.

That's partly because of our inescapable human limitations—we never know as much about the world as we would like to know, and we don't know our own motivations as well as we tend to believe we do. The world is often a mystery, and just as often we are a mystery to ourselves. We operate with incomplete information, always facing the temptation of self-serving self-delusion.

Complicating these limits is the human tendency to conform to the views of the social groups in which we anchor our sense of self. That's most obviously a problem for people in cults, although the line between a cult and what we take to be a normal social group can be hard to identify at times. (I'm kidding, sort of.) However cultish our particular groups, we all are social animals—we don't think, speak, or live alone. We don't construct the frameworks we use to navigate the world by ourselves, and we often rely on the conclusions of others who have expertise—or at least, claim expertise—in areas that baffle us. Given the rapid expansion of human knowledge in the era of modern science, being routinely baffled is part of the modern condition.

Being part of groups gives us a sense of belonging and often a sense of collective power. For most of us, going along with our crowd makes us feel good, and we are reluctant to break ranks. The threat of being cast out of a group is a powerful motivator to accept beliefs, even when we have our doubts. Some people like to think they are beyond such pressures, deriding the conformists as "sheeple" who operate intellectually like domesticated animals. If we separate ourselves from crowds that we have been part of and challenge the belief systems of our peers, it's tempting to think of ourselves as operating outside the influence of a crowd. But even the crankiest contrarians are never really thinking on their own.

In my five decades of life in and around journalism, academia, and politics, I have never met anyone who thought alone. Throughout history there have been trailblazers, of course, people who have pushed beyond existing thinking to generate new ideas. But if contrarians believe they have special status—if they indulge the illusion

of having risen above the collective thinking process—they are failing to practice the critical self-reflection that is supposed to be a core attribute of contrarians.

We are herd animals, and we often unthinkingly think as a herd. The fancy term for this is "identity-protective cognition," the tendency of individuals to resolve disputed facts in a manner supportive of their group identities.¹ We are motivated to adopt those beliefs to signal that we belong. Here's another fancy term: "cultural cognition of risk," our tendency to form beliefs about dangers to society that are consistent with our value judgments about what constitutes an ideal society.² We are motivated to assess the facts about potentially dangerous behaviors in ways that support policies we already endorse. Both of these are forms of what is often called "motivated reasoning," when our biases lead us to a particular conclusion or decision, often without any conscious awareness.

But the herd isn't always right, and we are often not very good at assessing risk. No group of people is infallible, just as no individual is infallible, and different herds can have mutually exclusive notions of how to understand a situation, which means at least one herd in such a debate is wrong, in part or totally. None of this should surprise anyone. As three scholars of language and intelligence explain, human learning is creative, which means: [A]ny human-style explanation is not necessarily correct; we are fallible. But this is part of what it means to think: To be right, it must be possible to be wrong. Intelligence consists not only of creative conjectures but also of creative criticism. Human-style thought is based on possible explanations and error correction, a process that gradually limits what possibilities can be rationally considered.³

Because we are fallible, it's best that in our herds we encourage each other to stay sharp. In the smallest herds to which we belong—groups that usually are defined by shared values and tastes—we should reward people for speaking up to challenge the presumed wisdom of the herd. We should encourage lively internal debate. If we're successful at cultivating that virtue in smaller circles, we can encourage it in more diverse groups, where disagreements are likely more contentious.

I am a herd animal, no different than anyone else. Because of early experience of not fitting into "normal" social groups (that's a long story about a weird kid), I developed a contrarian streak. But I am always aware that I don't think alone. All that said, I am eager to offer the conclusions I've reached about contemporary issues with confidence, even when—perhaps especially when—members of my herd disagree.

Here's a quick summary of my evaluation of contemporary herds: I think the right-wing herd is misguided more often than it is correct, but I agree with some elements of a truly conservative worldview, especially the recognition that we humans and our systems aren't perfectible. I think the left-wing herd is correct most of the time, but my preference for leftist conclusions does not lead me to always accept the conventional wisdom of the left, which I believe is sometimes misguided.

That's enough background to make my intentions in this book clear: I will critique right-wing ideology, and I will point out what I believe to be failures of my left-leaning comrades, all the time trying to be as open as possible to critique from all sides, with the least amount of self-righteousness possible.

Like everyone, I think with others, and yet I'm responsible for defending my conclusions. Like everyone, I should work to get better at acquiring and analyzing

information, as well as cultivating honest introspection. Acknowledging our intellectual interdependence in making our way through the world—even celebrating it, since I can’t imagine living a truly solitary intellectual life—doesn’t negate the equally obvious fact that I am an individual with a capacity to follow my own judgments in thinking, speaking, and acting.

I am not an island unto myself, and yet I recognize that there are times I may reject what others on the island believe to be true.

It makes no sense to declare myself to be the captain of my own intellectual ship and ignore the wisdom of the crew. But neither does it make sense to blow whichever way the social winds take me.

OK, enough with the mixed metaphors. Back to plain language.

Because I know that I sometimes will be wrong, I appreciate someone telling me, “Your argument is unsound and here’s why.” Because I know others sometimes will be wrong, I am skeptical when someone tells me, “It’s wrong for you to make that argument and I won’t listen.” I have run into that latter response more often in the past decade of my intellectual and political life than in previous decades, which is a large part of my motivation to write this book.

Authenticity

As diligently as we may study the world and reflect on our motivations, as staunchly as we may vow not to just follow the crowd, it’s not easy to think freely, speak responsibly, and live authentically.

That last term is especially hard. I mean “authenticity” not in the sense of adherence to an original, not the quest to act in accordance with a revered tradition, whether real or mythical. That kind of search for the authentic—the belief there is a “true” practice or form validated by the unquestioned superiority of tradition—is an abandonment of our responsibility to deal with a changing world. I am using “authentic” here in the sense of being true to our own professed values, that struggle to be the person we claim to be, yearn to be. That is what my late friend Abe Osheroff meant when he so often spoke of his struggle to live an authentic life, to integrate his thinking, talking, and acting.

I met Abe through our mutual involvement in the antiwar movement and progressive political organizing more generally. Already in his eighties when I met him (he died in 2008 at the age of ninety-two), Abe began his political activism during his teenage years in Brooklyn during the Great Depression. He had been a labor organizer, had traveled to Spain to fight in that country’s civil war, and was involved in radical politics the rest of his life.

Abe didn’t write much, and so I recorded an extended interview with him in 2005,⁴ which led to a documentary film about his activism.⁵ After noticing that he often invoked authenticity, I asked him what he meant by the term. Here’s his answer from that interview: Authenticity is incredibly important. To me, authenticity comes when your thoughts, your words, and your deeds have some relation to each other. It comes when there’s a real organic relationship between the way you think, the way you talk, and the way you act. You have to fight for authenticity all the time in this world, and if you don’t fight for it you will get derailed. But when you have it, when

you feel that surge of recognition—that I’m saying exactly what I’m thinking, and I’m ready to do something about it.

Some people are afraid to think, because thinking can present problems. When you have thoughts, you have to decide what to do with them. We can save them and take them to a therapist, or we can go to a bar and drink them away, or we can talk about them. But immediately we have to deal with self-censorship. Talking honestly can have consequences. Take an easy example. If you’re involved in a relationship and there’s something bothering you about the relationship, and you tell the other person your thoughts, that may be the end of the relationship. You’re in a funny bind because if you talk about it you may risk the relationship, but if you don’t talk about it you know that down the road the same problem will be there. What do you do? Authenticity is about making that decision.

Then once you’ve said something, the question is, “What are you going to do about it?” A lot of people don’t do anything. Trying to be authentic is another way of saying you are struggling to let out the best part of who you are, the part that will act and take risks. We all have a choice: We can choose to be made by history, or we can choose to participate in making history.

This book is my attempt to be as authentic as possible. Because it’s arrogant to tell others how they should think, speak, and act, I’m offering no such advice. Rather than pretend I have it all figured out, I want to write about how I’ve struggled to figure it out in my own life, and why I have confidence in the things I think I have figured out.

This is not false modesty—there are some things I think I do well and some things I realize I’m not particularly good at. From an early age, growing up in North Dakota, I excelled at shoveling snow. Now in my sixties and living in northern New Mexico, I still take pride in my shoveling prowess and have expanded my skill set to include digging irrigation ditches. I also am a clear and concise writer, and I believe I became a pretty good college teacher. I have had some success in my life—I retired as a full professor from the University of Texas at Austin and have published a number of books—and I’ve tried to reflect honestly on the reasons for that success, beyond the obvious (that is, lots of dumb luck and being born white and male in the United States during economic boom times).

Mediocrity and stubbornness

Here’s what I’ve concluded: The secret of my success is that I’m mediocre, and I know it.

That’s what I told many of the graduate students I worked with at UT. I didn’t mean that I was unqualified for my job but rather that I tried not to overestimate my abilities. In academic life, people tend to scramble around trying to prove how smart they are. Because graduate students often mimic the behavior of faculty members, I wanted them to realize that there was a path forward that didn’t require them to overdrive their headlights.

I learned that lesson from a trusted friend, the late Jim Koplin,⁶ who told me that one could thrive in university life without pretending to be the smartest person in the room. My intellectual deficiencies are too numerous to list in full here, but among them are a tin ear for languages (I’m monolingual), a severely limited capacity for

math beyond algebra (I washed out of calculus in high school and was too lazy to try again), and an embarrassingly superficial knowledge of core sciences such as physics (please don't ask me to explain the general theory of relativity). I'll leave an evaluation of my emotional intelligence to others.

While I was working on my PhD, Jim told me, kindly but bluntly, that I lacked the background in math and science I should have; that at my age I was unlikely to make much progress in those areas; and that these weaknesses would limit the research I was competent to do. That was one of many things he was right about.

But Jim also helped me understand what I could be good at, such as distinguishing between important and trivial research in the social sciences and humanities, and then translating the best of it into plain language for students and the general public. He encouraged me to write honestly about my experience living with unearned privilege, incorporating critical self-reflection into radical analyses.

I'm mediocre. Not only do I know it, but I'm kind of proud of it, of how I have worked hard to maximize my limited abilities. Instead of always trying to puff up myself, I found ways to do what I did best within those limitations, aware that I wasn't creating new knowledge but helping others learn. Thanks to a lot of luck, I was able to build a successful professional career and also use those skills in political writing, public speaking, and community organizing.

That explains why I have the opportunity to write a book. Another trait of mine explains why I'm writing this book: I'm stubborn.

I hope my stubbornness is not the pathological kind, the annoying tendency we humans have to refuse to change our minds even when presented with incontrovertible evidence that we are wrong. I want to believe I am stubborn in the good sense, not abandoning a reasonable position I hold until someone presents such evidence. Like everyone, sometimes I have been stubborn in that embarrassing fashion. But as I have gotten older, I think I'm clearer about the difference between digging in for the sake of staying dug in, and holding one's ground because intellectual standards matter. I like to think I'm stubborn the right way.

I am mediocre and stubborn, proudly.

I realize that this may not be the smartest strategy for an introduction. So, I might as well keep digging this hole by telling a story about my own failure to live up to the standards I want to defend in this book.

In 2022, Wes Jackson and I published *An Inconvenient Apocalypse: Environmental Collapse, Climate Crisis, and the Fate of Humanity*,⁷ a book about dealing with today's "multiple cascading ecological crises," a phrase I had borrowed from Jim Koplin many years before.⁸ One of the "Four Hard Questions" that Wes and I take on in that book is overpopulation, asking a question that no one can answer definitively but is crucial to ask: What is the sustainable size of the human population, at what level of aggregate consumption? (If you don't want to read the book, our answer is "fewer and less", fewer people consuming a lot less, which I'll explain in Chapter 6.)

I was talking to a friend about how so many people on the left side of the political fence refuse to acknowledge that the question is relevant. Standard left dogma is that the problem is not population but capitalism—if the world's resources were distributed equitably, there would be enough for everyone. This dodge—it's econom-

ics not population—is a serious deficiency of left analysis, I told my friend, because it avoids coming to terms with the biophysical limits of the larger living world of which we are but one part.

Brief uncomfortable pause.

"When I asked you about population a long time ago," my friend said, "you told me that it wasn't important. Your answer was that the problem was capitalism. You gave me what you are now calling left dogma."

Another brief uncomfortable pause.

I had two possible responses. I could construct some tortured explanation of how my past comments were more nuanced and that what I had really meant was...

I spared us both that torture and agreed. Yes, I said, you're absolutely right. For a long time, I repeated that dogma, even though I was never sure it made sense. I didn't challenge the claim because I hadn't read widely enough or spent enough time thinking about the question, and so I said what people of my political leanings were supposed to say. I stuck with the herd. I wanted to be seen as a good leftist, and that was lazy. Reasonable people can disagree about the issue, but accepting dogma to avoid thinking is bad intellectual practice and contributes to bad public policy. In other words, I may be wrong about my conclusion today, but I definitely was wrong simply to repeat the party line for so long.

This story demonstrates two of my deepest insights about people: We are fallible, and we don't like being fallible.

OK, those aren't deep insights. They are banal observations—banal but important reminders of why honest arguments are necessary if we are to deepen our understanding of the world. Honest arguments are most productive when we commit to thinking freely, speaking responsibly, and acting authentically; when we do our best as individuals to uphold intellectual standards; and when we recognize that upholding those standards is as much a collective as an individual effort.

We all are responsible for cultivating these intellectual, moral, and political virtues in ourselves. But we need a little help not just from our friends but also from our enemies. That can be hard these days—not just finding a way to talk to enemies but also being honest with friends.

A note on terminology

So far, I have invoked a right/left political framework rather than a conservative/liberal one, which I hope will minimize confusion throughout the book. But confusion is inevitable.

Take the word "liberal", which is a component of the terms "classical liberalism", "New Deal liberalism", and "neoliberalism"—three very different political formations. The term is also used as a modifier, such as a "liberal internationalist," someone committed to building a world order based on principle not power. These days, the antonym "illiberal" is used to describe authoritarian leaders who manipulate democratic systems to produce undemocratic ends. Without shared definitions, these terms can confuse more than to clarify.

A leading liberal political philosopher suggests that "liberal" makes most sense as an adjective that captures a spirit best described in moral rather than political or

cultural terms: We [liberals] are, or we aspire to be, open-minded, generous, and tolerant. We are able to live with ambiguity; we are ready for arguments that we don't feel we have to win. Whatever our ideology, whatever our religion, we are not dogmatic; we are not fanatics.⁹

This book embraces those liberal values, but I am a leftist (not a liberal) who is rooted in radical (not liberal) feminism. So, what am I?

That question can be hard to answer when there are no stable, widely agreed upon definitions. A politician such as Nancy Pelosi, the former Speaker of the House of Representatives, might be described by her Democratic Party supporters as a liberal, while people further to the left might consider her to be a moderate. Meanwhile, conservative opponents routinely tagged her as far left.

For purposes of this book, I will try to stick with definitions that are most commonly used in contemporary US politics. From my perspective, the contemporary right in the United States includes openly fascistic, reactionary, and moderate versions. In the center are, well, centrists. On the left we find liberals, progressives, and leftists.

The fascistic right includes those who openly call for the United States to be a white, Christian nation and hold strong patriarchal views and a weak commitment to democracy.¹⁰ The reactionary right includes those who believe any capitulation to democratic socialism, multiculturalism, or internationalism will destroy the country. The moderate right is the rest of the Republican Party, those who are skeptical of any restraint on the business community and are committed to US supremacy, whether it be through intervention or isolation.

Liberals offer a tempered critique of concentrated power, endorsing reforms to capitalism that include greater opportunities for women and non-white people within the existing systems. Progressives have a deeper critique of those systems but tend to be pragmatic and avoid calls for radical change. Leftists argue that we must abandon those systems and find new ways of organizing the economy and international order, typically around socialist principles.

Who does that leave in the center? People who are uncomfortable with too much change too quickly, those willing to accept most any policy proposal that promises stability and protects the status quo.

In this summary, I have not included positions on the ecological crises, which don't always map easily onto left/right frameworks, though in general the left side of the fence takes those crises more seriously than the right. But as I'll argue in Chapter 6, the differences in right and left on these matters may not be as important as their unacknowledged points of agreement.

At times I'll talk about right and left in general ways, recognizing that there are important distinctions within those groupings but that for certain purposes the binary is adequate. When the distinctions are more central to any analysis, I'll mark them.

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Israel's Descent

ADAM SHATZ

When Ariel Sharon withdrew more than eight thousand Jewish settlers from the Gaza Strip in 2005, his principal aim was to consolidate Israel's colonisation of the West Bank, where the settler population immediately began to increase. But 'disengagement' had another purpose: to enable Israel's air force to bomb Gaza at will, something they could not do when Israeli settlers lived there. The Palestinians of the West Bank have been, it seems, gruesomely lucky. They are encircled by settlers determined to steal their lands—and not at all hesitant about inflicting violence in the process—but the Jewish presence in their territory has spared them the mass bombardment and devastation to which Israel subjects the people of Gaza every few years.

The Israeli government refers to these episodes of collective punishment as 'mowing the lawn'. In the last fifteen years, it has launched five offensives in the Strip. The first four were brutal and cruel, as colonial counterinsurgencies invariably are, killing thousands of civilians in retribution for Hamas rocket fire and hostage-taking. But the latest, Operation Iron Swords, launched on 7 October in response to Hamas's murderous raid in southern Israel, is different in kind, not merely in degree. Over the last eight months, Israel has killed more than 36,000 Palestinians. An untold number remain under the debris and still more will die of hunger and disease. Eighty thousand Palestinians have been injured, many of them permanently maimed. Children whose parents—whose entire families—have been killed constitute a new population sub-group. Israel has destroyed Gaza's housing infrastructure, its hospitals, and all its universities. Most of Gaza's 2.3 million residents have been displaced, some of them repeatedly; many have fled to 'safe' areas only to be bombed there. No one has been spared: aid workers, journalists, and medics have been killed in record numbers. And as levels of starvation have risen, Israel has created one obstacle after another to the provision of food, all while insisting that its army is the 'most moral' in the world. The images from Gaza—widely available on TikTok, which Israel's supporters in the US have tried to ban, and on Al Jazeera, whose Jerusalem office was shut down by the Israeli government—tell a different story, one of famished Palestinians killed outside aid trucks on Al-Rashid Street in February; of tent-dwellers in Rafah burned alive in Israeli air strikes; of women and children subsisting on 245 calories a day. This is what Benjamin Netanyahu describes as 'the victory of Judaeo-Christian civilisation against barbarism'.

The military operation in Gaza has altered the shape, perhaps even the meaning, of the struggle over Palestine—it seems misleading, and even offensive, to refer to a 'conflict' between two peoples after one of them has slaughtered the other in such staggering numbers. The scale of the destruction is reflected in the terminology: 'domicide' for the destruction of housing stock; 'scholasticide' for the

destruction of the education system, including its teachers (95 university professors have been killed); 'ecocide' for the ruination of Gaza's agriculture and natural landscape. Sara Roy, a leading expert on Gaza who is herself the daughter of Holocaust survivors, describes this as a process of 'econocide', 'the wholesale destruction of an economy and its constituent parts'—the 'logical extension', she writes, of Israel's deliberate 'de-development' of Gaza's economy since 1967.

But, to borrow the language of a 1948 UN convention, there is an older term for 'acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnic, racial, or religious group'. That term is genocide, and among international jurists and human rights experts there is a growing consensus that Israel has committed genocide—or at least acts of genocide—in Gaza. This is the opinion not only of international bodies, but also of experts who have a record of circumspection—indeed, of extreme caution—where Israel is involved, notably Aryeh Neier, a founder of Human Rights Watch.

The charge of genocide isn't new among Palestinians. I remember hearing it when I was in Beirut in 2002, during Israel's assault on the Jenin refugee camp, and thinking, no, it's a ruthless, pitiless siege. The use of the word 'genocide' struck me then as typical of the rhetorical inflation of Middle East political debate, and as a symptom of the bitter, ugly competition over victimhood in Israel-Palestine. The game had been rigged against Palestinians because of their oppressors' history: the destruction of European Jewry conferred moral capital on the young Jewish state in the eyes of the Western powers. The Palestinian claim of genocide seemed like a bid to even the score, something that words such as 'occupation' and even 'apartheid' could never do.

This time it's different, however, not only because of the wanton killing of thousands of women and children, but because the sheer scale of the devastation has rendered life itself all but impossible for those who have survived Israel's bombardment. The war was provoked by Hamas's unprecedented attack, but the desire to inflict suffering on Gaza, not just on Hamas, didn't arise on 7 October. Here is Ariel Sharon's son Gilad in 2012: 'We need to flatten entire neighbourhoods in Gaza. Flatten all of Gaza. The Americans didn't stop with Hiroshima—the Japanese weren't surrendering fast enough, so they hit Nagasaki, too. There should be no electricity in Gaza, no gasoline or moving vehicles, nothing.' Today this reads like a prophecy.

Exterminationist violence is almost always preceded by other forms of persecution, which aim to render the victims as miserable as possible, including plunder, denial of the franchise, ghettoisation, ethnic cleansing and racist dehumanisation. All of these have been features of Israel's relationship to the Palestinian people since its founding. What causes persecution to slide into mass killing is usually war, in particular a war defined as an existential battle for survival—as we have seen in the war on Gaza. The statements of Israel's leaders (the defence minister, Yoav Gallant: 'We are fighting human animals, and we will act accordingly'; President Isaac Herzog: 'It is an entire nation out there that is responsible') have not disguised their intentions but provided a precise guide. So have the gleeful selfies taken by Israeli

soldiers amid the ruins of Gaza: for some, at least, its destruction has been a source of pleasure.

Israel's methods may bear a closer resemblance to those of the French in Algeria, or the Assad regime in Syria, than to those of the Nazis in Treblinka or the Hutu génocidaires in Rwanda, but this doesn't mean they do not constitute genocide. Nor does the fact that Israel has killed 'only' a portion of Gaza's population. What, after all, is left for those who survive? Bare life, as Giorgio Agamben calls it: an existence menaced by hunger, destitution and the ever present threat of the next airstrike (or 'tragic accident', as Netanyahu described the incineration of 45 civilians in Rafah). Israel's supporters might argue that this is not the Shoah, but the belief that the best way of honouring the memory of those who died in Auschwitz is to condone the mass killing of Palestinians so that Israeli Jews can feel safe again is one of the great moral perversions of our time.

In Israel, this belief amounts to an article of faith. Netanyahu may be despised by half the population but his war on Gaza is not, and according to recent polls, a substantial majority of Israelis think either that his response has been appropriate or that it hasn't gone far enough. Unable or unwilling to look beyond the atrocities of 7 October, most of Israel's Jews regard themselves as fully justified in waging war until Hamas is destroyed, even—or especially—if this means the total destruction of Gaza. They reject the idea that Israel's own conduct—its suffocation of Gaza, its colonisation of the West Bank, its use of apartheid, its provocations at Al-Aqsa Mosque, its continuing denial of Palestinian self-determination—might have led to the furies of 7 October. Instead, they insist that they are once again the victims of antisemitism, of 'Amalek', the enemy nation of the Israelites. That Israelis cannot see, or refuse to see, their own responsibility in the making of 7 October is a testament to their ancestral fears and terrors, which have been rekindled by the massacres. But it also reveals the extent to which Israeli Jews inhabit what Jean Daniel called 'the Jewish prison'.

Zionism's original ambition was to transform Jews into historical actors: sovereign, legitimate, endowed with a sense of power and agency. But the tendency of Israeli Jews to see themselves as eternal victims, among other habits of the diaspora, has proved stronger than Zionism itself, and Israel's leaders have found a powerful ideological armour, and source of cohesion, in this reflex. It is hardly surprising that Israelis have interpreted 7 October as a sequel to the Holocaust, or that their leaders have encouraged this interpretation: both adhere to a theological reading of history based on mythic repetition, in which any violence against Jews, regardless of the context, is understood within a continuum of persecution; they are incapable of distinguishing between violence against Jews as Jews, and violence against Jews in connection with the practices of the Jewish state. (Ironically, this vision of history renders the industrialised killing of the Shoah less exceptional, since it appears simply to be a big pogrom.) What this means, in practice, is that anyone who faults Israel for its policies before 7 October, or for its slaughter in Gaza, can be dismissed as an antisemite, a friend of Hamas, Iran, and Hizbullah, of Amalek.

It also means that almost anything is justified on the battlefield, where a growing number of soldiers in combat units are extremist settlers. It is not uncommon to hear Israeli Jews defending the killing of children, since they would grow up to be terrorists (an argument no different from the claim by some Palestinians that to kill an Israeli Jewish child is to kill a future IDF soldier). The question is how many Palestinian children must die before Israelis feel safe—or whether Israeli Jews regard the removal of the Palestinian population as a necessary condition of their security.

The Zionist idea of ‘transfer’—the expulsion of the Arab population—is older than Israel itself. It was embraced both by Ben-Gurion and by his rival Vladimir Jabotinsky, the Revisionist Zionist who was a mentor to Netanyahu’s father, and it fed directly into the expulsions of the 1948 war. But until the 1980s, and the rise of the New Historians, Israel strenuously denied that it had committed ethnic cleansing, claiming that Palestinians had left or ‘fled’ because the invading Arab armies had encouraged them to do so; when the expulsion of the Palestinians and the destruction of their villages were evoked, as in S. Yizhar’s 1949 novella *Khirbet Khizeh* and A.B. Yehoshua’s 1963 story ‘Facing the Forests’, it was with anguish and guilt-laden rationalisation. But, as the French journalist Sylvain Cypel points out in *The State of Israel v. the Jews*, the ‘secret shame underlying the denial’ has evaporated. Today the catastrophe of 1948 is brazenly defended in Israel as a necessity—and viewed as an uncompleted, even heroic, project. Bezalel Smotrich, the minister of finance, and Itamar Ben-Gvir, the minister of national security, are both unabashed advocates of transfer. What we are witnessing in Gaza is something more than the most murderous chapter in the history of Israel-Palestine: it is the culmination of the 1948 Nakba and the transformation of Israel, a state that once provided a sanctuary for survivors of the death camps, into a nation guilty of genocide.

‘There are decades where nothing happens,’ Lenin wrote, ‘and there are weeks where decades happen.’ The last eight months have seen an extraordinary acceleration of Israel’s long war against the Palestinians. Could the history of Zionism have turned out otherwise? Benjamin Netanyahu is a callow man of limited imagination, driven in large part by his appetite for power and his desire to avoid conviction for fraud and bribery (his trial has been running intermittently since early 2020). But he is also Israel’s longest-serving prime minister, and his expansionist, racist ideology is the Israeli mainstream. Always an ethocracy based on Jewish privilege, Israel has, under his watch, become a reactionary nationalist state, a country that now officially belongs exclusively to its Jewish citizens. Or in the words of the nation-state law of 2018, which enshrines Jewish supremacy: ‘The right to exercise national self-determination in the state of Israel is unique to the Jewish people.’ It’s no wonder Palestinians and their supporters proclaim: ‘Palestine shall be free from the river to the sea.’ What many Zionists hear as a call to ethnic cleansing or genocide is, for most Palestinians, a call for an end to Jewish supremacy over the entirety of the land—an end to conditions of total unfreedom.

It isn’t surprising that on the student left the word ‘Zionist’ has become an epithet for those who oppose equal rights and freedom for Palestinians, or who,

even if they claim to endorse the idea of a Palestinian state, persist in thinking that the desires of Israeli Jews, by virtue of their ancestors’ persecution in Europe, outweigh those of Palestine’s indigenous Arabs. But, as Shlomo Sand reminds us in *Deux peuples pour un état*,² there was another, dissident Zionism, a ‘cultural Zionism’ that advocated the creation of a binational state based on Arab-Jewish cooperation, one that counted among its members Ahad Ha’am, Judah Magnes, Martin Buber, and Hannah Arendt. In 1907, the cultural Zionist Yitzhak Epstein accused the Zionist movement of having forgotten ‘one small detail: that there is in our beloved land an entire people that has been attached to it for hundreds of years and has never considered leaving it.’ Epstein and his allies, who founded Brit Shalom, the Alliance for Peace, in 1925, imagined Zion as a place of cultural and spiritual rebirth. Any attempt to create an exclusively Jewish state, they warned, would turn Zionism into a classical colonial movement and result in permanent warfare with the Palestinian Arabs. After the Arab riots of 1929, Brit Shalom’s secretary, Hans Kohn, denounced the official Zionist movement for ‘adopting the posture of wounded innocents’ and for dodging ‘the least debate with the people who live in this country. We have depended entirely on the force of British power. We have set ourselves goals that were inevitably going to degenerate into conflict.’

But this was no accident: conflict with the Arabs was essential to the Zionist mainstream. For the advocates of ‘muscular Zionism’, as Amnon Raz-Krakotzkin has argued, the creation of a Jewish state in Palestine would allow Jews not only to achieve the ‘negation of exile’ but also, and paradoxically, to reinvent themselves as citizens of the white West—in Herzl’s words, as a ‘rampart of Europe against Asia’. Brit Shalom’s vision of reconciliation and co-operation with the indigenous population was unthinkable to most Zionists, because they regarded the Arabs of Palestine as squatters on sacred Jewish land. And, as Ben-Gurion put it, ‘we don’t want Israelis to be Arabs. It’s our duty to fight against the Levantine mentality that destroys individuals and societies.’ In 1933, Brit Shalom folded; a year later, Kohn left Palestine in despair, convinced that the Zionist movement was on a collision course with the Palestinians and the region.

Ben-Gurion’s movement was also on a collision course with those who, like Kohn and Arendt, sympathised with the idea of a Jewish cultural sanctuary in Palestine, but rejected the maximalist, exclusionary, territorial vision of the state associated with Israel’s creation in 1948. Jewish critics of Israel who traced their roots to the cultural Zionism of Magnes and Buber—or to the anti-Zionist Jewish Labor Bund—would find themselves vilified as heretics and traitors. In *Our Palestine Question*, Geoffrey Levin shows how American Jewish critics of Israel were dislodged from Jewish institutions in the decades following the state’s formation. After the 1948 war, the American Jewish press featured extensive, and largely sympathetic, coverage of the plight of Palestinian refugees: Israel had not yet declared that it would not readmit a single refugee. ‘The question of the Arab refugees is a moral issue which rises above diplomacy,’ William Zukerman, the editor of the Jewish Newsletter, wrote in 1950. ‘The land now called Israel belongs to the Arab Refugees no less than to any Israeli. They have lived on that soil and worked on

it... for twelve hundred years... The fact that they fled in panic is no excuse for depriving them of their homes.' Under Israeli pressure, Zukerman lost his job as a New York correspondent for the London-based *Jewish Chronicle*. Arthur Lourie, the Israeli consul general in New York, exulted in his firing: 'a real *mitzvah*'.

Zukerman wasn't alone. In 1953, the American Reform rabbi Morris Lazaron recited a prayer of atonement in the Shatila refugee camp in Beirut, declaring 'we have sinned' and calling for the immediate repatriation of a hundred thousand refugees: as members of the 'tribe of the wandering feet', he said, Jews should stand with Palestine's refugees. The leading expert in the US on the Palestinian refugees, Don Peretz, was employed by the American Jewish Committee (AJC). After the 1948 war, he worked with a Quaker group that distributed food and clothing to displaced Palestinians living under Israel's military government. Horrified to discover 'an attitude towards the Arabs which resembles that of American racists', Peretz wrote a pamphlet on the refugees for the AJC. Israeli officials responded by trying to have him fired; Esther Herlitz, Israel's consul in New York, recommended that the embassy 'consider digging him a grave' at the Jewish college in Pennsylvania where he taught. Peretz was not a radical: he simply wanted to create what he called 'a platform from which to voice not only eulogies of Israel, but a critical concern about many of the problems with which the new state has become involved', above all the 'Arab refugee problem, the condition of Israel's Arab minority'. Instead, he encountered an 'emotional environment' that made it 'as difficult to create an atmosphere for free discussion as it is in the South today to discuss interracial relations'.

Among the most illuminating episodes recounted in Levin's book is the campaign to smear the reputation of Faye Sayegh, the leading Palestinian spokesman in the US in the 1950s and early 1960s. A native of Tiberias, 'Sayegh understood acutely that any Arab flirtation with antisemites tarnished their cause,' Levin writes, and so steered clear of neo-Nazis and other anti-Jewish activists who turned up at his door. He joined forces with an anti-Zionist rabbi, Elmer Berger of the American Council for Judaism, who had already established himself as a critic of Zionism in his 1951 book, *A Partisan History of Judaism*, in which he assailed the movement for embracing 'Hitler's decree of separatism' and betraying Judaism's universalist message. Described by a pro-Israel activist as 'one of the most competent polemicists that American Jewry has ever had to counteract', Sayegh was considered especially dangerous because he could not easily be painted as an antisemite. In their efforts to combat this Arab ally of a prominent, if controversial, rabbi who never succumbed to antisemitic rhetoric, Zionist activists were forced to invent a novel charge: that anti-Zionism was itself a form of antisemitism. The Anti-Defamation League developed this argument into a book in 1974, but, as Levin shows, it was already in circulation twenty years earlier.

Sayegh eventually moved to Beirut, where he joined the PLO. And in the wake of the Six-Day War in 1967, the American Jewish community underwent what Norman Podhoretz called a 'complete Zionisation'. As Joshua Leifer argues in his new book, *Tablets Shattered*, the Jewish establishment became increasingly

'particularist, their rhetoric blunter in its defence of Jewish self-interest'. That establishment continues to exert influence in American institutions of power and higher learning: the downfall of Claudine Gay, the Harvard president, engineered by the Zionist billionaire Bill Ackman, is just one illustration. As Leifer writes, the uncritical embrace of Zionism has 'engendered a moral myopia' with respect to Israel's oppression of Palestinians. The far left's denial that Hamas committed any atrocities on 7 October is mirrored by the genocide denialism of American Jews who claim there is plenty of food in Gaza and that Palestinian starvation is simply a form of theatre.

This moral myopia has always been resisted by a minority of American Jews. There have been successive waves of resistance, provoked by previous episodes of Israeli brutality: the Lebanon War, the First Intifada, the Second Intifada. But the most consequential wave of resistance may be the one we are seeing now from a generation of young Jews for whom identification with an explicitly illiberal, openly racist state, led by a close ally of Donald Trump, is impossible to stomach. As Peter Beinart wrote in 2010, the Jewish establishment asked American Jews to 'check their liberalism at Zionism's door', only to find that 'many young Jews had checked their Zionism instead.'

The conflict that Beinart described is an old one. In 1967, I.F. Stone wrote: Israel is creating a kind of moral schizophrenia in world Jewry. In the outside world the welfare of Jewry depends on the maintenance of secular, non-racial, pluralistic societies. In Israel, Jewry finds itself defending a society in which mixed marriages cannot be legalised, in which non-Jews have a lesser status than Jews, and in which the ideal is racial and exclusionist. Jews must fight elsewhere for their very security and existence — against principles and practices they find themselves defending in Israel.

Among many young American Jewish liberals, this contradiction has proved intolerable: Jewish students have made up an unusually high number of the protesters on campus.

They have also tried to develop what Leifer calls 'new expressions of Jewish identity and community... untethered to Israeli militarism'. Some, like Leifer, express an affinity for traditional, even Orthodox Judaism, because of its distance from the anything-goes liberalism of American Judaism, even as they deplore Israel's human rights abuses. The most radical among them have espoused a 'soft diaspora nationalism', disavowing any ties to Israel, proclaiming their support for the boycott, divestment, and sanctions movement and embracing the symbols of the Palestinian struggle. Leifer is troubled by the failure of some Jews to criticise the 7 October attacks. He accuses them of 'callousness towards the lives of other Jews, whose ancestors happened to flee to the embattled, fledgling Jewish state, instead of the United States'.

The cool response to the events of 7 October that critics such as Leifer find so disturbing, particularly when expressed by left-wing Jews, may not reflect callousness so much as a conscious act of disaffiliation, bred by shame and a sense of unwanted complicity with a state that insists on loyalty from Jews throughout the

world—as well as a repudiation of the Zionist movement's claim that Jews comprise a single, united people with a shared destiny. Leifer's book is a critique of the Jewish prison, written from within its walls: 'renunciation' of Israel, he insists, is impossible because it will soon contain the majority of the world's Jews, 'a revolution in the basic conditions of Jewish existence'. Those who prioritise their membership of a larger secular community seek to liberate themselves from the prison altogether, even at the risk of being excommunicated as 'un-Jews'. For these writers and activists, many of them gathered around the revived journal *Jewish Currents* and the activist organization Jewish Voice for Peace, fidelity with the principles of ethical Judaism requires them to adopt what Krakotzkin calls 'the perspective of the expelled'—who, since 1948, have been Palestinian, not Jewish.

'We have no known Einsteins, no Chagall, no Freud or Rubinstein to protect us with a legacy of glorious achievements,' Edward Said wrote of the Palestinians in 1986. 'We have had no Holocaust to protect us with the world's compassion. We are "other", and opposite, a flaw in the geometry of resettlement and exodus.' Palestinians are still 'others' in the moral calculus of the US and Western powers, without whose support Israel could not have carried out its assault on Gaza. But they can now invoke a genocide of their own, and though it may not yet offer them protection, it has done much to diminish Israel's already-eroded moral capital. Palestinian claims to the land and to justice, already embedded in the conscience of the Global South, have made extraordinary inroads into that of the liberal West, as well as that of American Jewry, in no small part thanks to Said and other Palestinian writers and activists. The birth of a global movement in opposition to Israel's war in Gaza, and in defence of Palestinian rights, is, if nothing else, a sign that Israel has lost the moral war among people of conscience. While the Palestinian cause is wedded to international justice, to solidarity among oppressed peoples, and to the preservation of a rules-based order, Israel's appeal is largely confined to religious Jews, the far right, white nationalists, and Democratic politicians of an older generation such as Joe Biden, who warned of a 'ferocious surge' in antisemitism in America following the protests, and Nancy Pelosi, who claimed to detect a 'Russian tinge' to them. When the Proud Boys' founder, Gavin McInnes, and the House Speaker, Mike Johnson, descended on Columbia's New York campus to defend Jewish students from 'antisemitic' protesters (among them Jews holding liberation seders), they looked as though they'd convened a 6 January reunion. For all their claims to isolation in a sea of sympathy for Palestine, Jewish supporters of Israel, like the state itself, have powerful allies in Washington, in the administration and on university boards.

The excessive, militarised reactions to the encampments at Columbia, UCLA, and elsewhere, along with the furious responses of the British, German, and French governments to demonstrations in London, Paris, and Berlin, are a measure of the movement's growing influence. As Régis Debray put it, 'the revolution revolutionises the counterrevolution.' A worrying development for anyone who cares about free speech and freedom of assembly, the clearing of the solidarity encampments by the police was a reminder that the rhetoric of 'safe spaces' can easily lend itself

to right-wing capture. The antisemitism bill recently passed in the House of Representatives threatens to stifle pro-Palestinian speech on American campuses, since university administrations could become liable for failing to enforce the International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance's definition of antisemitism, which conflates anti-Zionism and antisemitism. Like the anti-BDS measures adopted by more than thirty states, the Antisemitism Awareness Act is an expression of what Susan Neiman, writing about Germany's suppression of support for Palestinian rights, has called 'philosemitic McCarthyism', and will almost certainly lead to more antisemitism, since it treats Jewish students as a privileged minority whose feelings of safety require special legal protection. It only adds to the unreal quality of the debate in the US that the threat of antisemitism is being weaponised by right-wing Evangelicals who have otherwise made common cause with white nationalists and actual antisemites, while liberal Democratic politicians acquiesce.

After a New York City police officer took down a Palestinian flag at City College and replaced it with an American flag, Mayor Eric Adams said: 'Blame me for being proud to be an American... We're not surrendering our way of life to anyone.' This was, of course, a ludicrous expression of xenophobia—and it's hard to imagine Adams, or any American politician, making such a remark about those who wave the Ukrainian flag. (The NYPD filmed the clearing of the Columbia campus for a promotional video, as if it were an anti-terrorism raid.) But it's indicative of the casual racism, often laced with anti-Muslim and anti-Arab prejudice, that has long been directed against Palestinians. Said was called the 'professor of terror', Columbia's Middle East Studies Department 'Birzeit on the Hudson'. Bari Weiss, the former *New York Times* columnist who sees herself as a 'free speech warrior', cut her teeth as an undergraduate at Columbia trying to have members of the Middle East faculty fired. The campaign against Palestinian scholars, which helped lay the intellectual groundwork for the attack on the encampments, is instructive. Arafat was wrong when he said the Palestinians' greatest weapon is the womb of the Palestinian woman: it is the knowledge and documentation of what Israel has done, and is doing, to the Palestinian people. Hence Israel's looting of the Palestine Research Centre during the 1982 invasion of Lebanon and the attacks on professors who might shed light on a history some would prefer to suppress.

Has some of the rhetoric on US campuses slid into antisemitism? Have some Jewish supporters of Israel been bullied, physically or verbally? Yes, though the extent of anti-Jewish harassment remains unknown and contested. There is also the question, as Shaul Magid writes in *The Necessity of Exile*, of whether 'the single umbrella of antisemitism' best describes all these incidents. 'What is antisemitism if it is no longer accompanied by oppression?' Magid asks. 'What constitutes antisemitism when Jews are in fact the oppressors?'

Amid all the attention on heightened Jewish vulnerability, there has been little discussion of the vulnerability of Palestinian, Arab and Muslim students, much less an academic commission or political bill to address it. Unlike Jews, they have to prove their right simply to be on campus. Palestinians—particularly if they take part in protests—risk being seen as 'trespassers', infiltrators from a foreign land.

Last November, three Palestinian students visiting relatives in Vermont were shot by a racist fanatic; one of them will be paralysed for life. Biden did not respond to this or other attacks on Muslims by saying that 'silence is complicity', as he did about antisemitism.

It was, in fact, the refusal of silence, the refusal of complicity, that led students of every background into the streets in protest, at far greater risk to their futures than during the 2020 protests against police killings. Opposition to anti-black racism is embraced by elite liberals; opposition to Israel's wars against Palestine is not. They braved doxxing, the contempt of their university administrations, police violence, and in some cases expulsion. Prominent law firms have announced that they will not hire students who took part in the encampments.

The political establishment and the mainstream press were largely disdainful. Liberal commentators belittled the students as 'privileged', although many of them, particularly at state colleges, came from poor and working-class backgrounds; the protests, some claimed, were ultimately about America, not about the Middle East. (They were about both.) The protesters were also accused of making Jews feel unsafe with their ritualised denunciations of Zionism, of grandstanding, of engaging in a fantasy of 1968-style rebellion, of ignoring Hamas's cruelties or even justifying them, of romanticising armed struggle in their calls to 'globalise the intifada', of being possessed by a Manichean fervour that blinded them to the complexities of a war that involved multiple parties, not just Israel and Gaza.

There is, of course, a grain of truth to these criticisms. Like 'defund the police', 'from the river to the sea' is appealing in its absolutism, but also dangerously ambiguous, fuel for right-wing adversaries looking for evidence of calls for 'genocide' against Jews. And there was, as there always is, a theatrical dimension to the protests, with some students imagining themselves to be part of the same drama unfolding in Gaza, confusing the rough clearing of an encampment ('liberated zones') with the violent destruction of a refugee camp. But the attacks on the demonstrators—whether for 'privilege', supposed hostility to Jews, or fanaticism—weren't a fair portrayal of a broad-based movement that includes Palestinians and Jews, African Americans and Latinos, Christians and atheists.

For all their missteps, the students drew attention to matters that seemed to elude their detractors: the obscenity of Israel's war on Gaza; the complicity of their government in arming Israel and facilitating the slaughter; the hypocrisy of America's claim to defend human rights and a rules-based international order while giving Israel carte blanche; and the urgent need for a ceasefire. Nor were they cowed by Netanyahu's grotesque comparison of the protests to anti-Jewish mobilisations in German universities in the 1930s (where no one was holding seders). If Trump wins, they will be blamed, along with Arab and Muslim voters who can't bring themselves to vote for a president who armed Bibi, but they deserve credit for mobilising support for a ceasefire and for helping to shift the narrative on Palestine.

The destruction of Gaza will be as formative for them as the struggles against the Vietnam War, apartheid in South Africa, and the Iraq War were for earlier generations. Their image of a child murdered by a genocidal state will not be Anne

Frank but Hind Rajab, the six-year-old girl killed by Israeli tank fire as she sat in a car pleading for help, surrounded by the bodies of her murdered relatives. When they chant 'We are all Palestinians', they are moved by the same feeling of solidarity that led students in 1968 to chant 'Nous sommes tous des juifs allemands' after the German-Jewish student leader Daniel Cohn-Bendit was expelled from France. These are emotions of which no group of victims can forever remain the privileged beneficiary, not even the descendants of the European Jews who perished in the death camps.

As the historian Enzo Traverso has argued, a particular version of Holocaust remembrance, centred on Jewish suffering and the 'miraculous' founding of Israel, has been a 'civil religion' in the West since the 1970s. People in the Global South have never been parishioners of this church, not least because it has been linked to a reflexive defence of the state of Israel, described in Germany as a *Staatsräson*. For many Jews, steeped in Zionism's narrative of Jewish persecution and Israeli redemption, and encouraged to think that 1939 might be just around the corner, the fact that Palestinians, not Israelis, are seen by most people as Jews themselves once were—as victims of oppression and persecution, as stateless refugees—no doubt comes as a shock. Their reaction, naturally, is to steer the conversation back to the Holocaust, or to the events of 7 October. These anxieties shouldn't be dismissed. But, as James Baldwin wrote in the late 1960s, 'one does not wish... to be told by an American Jew that his suffering is as great as the American Negro's suffering. It isn't, and one knows it isn't from the very tone in which he assures you that it is.'

The question is how, if at all, these movements can help to end the war in Gaza, to end the occupation and the repressive matrix of control that affects all Palestinians, including Palestinian citizens of Israel, who make up a fifth of the population. While the justice of the Palestinian cause has never enjoyed wider or more universal recognition, and the BDS movement (vilified as 'antisemitic' and 'terrorist' by Israel's defenders) has never attracted comparable support, the Palestinian national movement itself is in almost complete disarray. The Palestinian Authority is an authority only in name, a virtual gendarme of Israel, reviled and mocked by those who live under it. It has been unable to protect Palestinians in the West Bank from the wave of settler attacks and military violence that has killed five hundred Palestinians in the last eight months and resulted in the theft of more than 37,000 acres of land, a creeping Gaza-fication. Palestinians inside Israel are under intense surveillance, ever at risk of being accused of treason, and left to the mercy of the criminal gangs that increasingly tyrannise Arab towns.

The future of Gaza looks still more bleak, even in the event of a long-term truce or ceasefire. 'Gaza 2035', a proposal circulated by Netanyahu's office, envisages it as a Gulf-style free-trade zone. Jared Kushner has his eye on beachfront developments, and the Israeli right is determined to re-establish settlements. As for the survivors of Israel's assault, the political scientist Nathan Brown predicts that they will be living in a 'supercamp', where, as he writes in *Deluge*, a collection of essays on the current war, 'law and order... will likely be handled—if they are

handled at all—by camp committees and self-appointed gangs.’ He adds: ‘This seems less like the day after a conflict than a long twilight of disintegration and despair.’

Disintegration and despair are, of course, the conditions that encourage the ‘terrorism’ that Israel claims to be fighting. And it would be easy for Gaza’s survivors to succumb to this temptation, particularly since they have been given no hope for a better life, much less a state, only lectures on the reason they ought to turn the Strip into the next Dubai rather than build tunnels.

Over the last eight months, Palestine has become to the American and UK student left what Ukraine is to liberals: the symbol of a pure struggle against aggression. But just as Zelensky’s admirers ignore the illiberal elements in the national movement, so Palestine’s supporters tend to overlook the brutality of Hamas, not only against Israeli Jews but against its Palestinian critics. As Isaac Deutscher wrote, while ‘the nationalism of the exploited and oppressed’ cannot be ‘put on the same moral-political level as the nationalism of conquerors and oppressors’, it ‘should not be viewed uncritically’.

In *The Hundred Years’ War on Palestine* (2020), Rashid Khalidi writes that when the Pakistani activist Eqbal Ahmad visited the PLO’s bases in southern Lebanon, ‘he returned with a critique that disconcerted those who had asked his advice. While in principle a supporter of armed struggle against colonial regimes such as that in Algeria... he questioned whether armed struggle was the right course of action against the PLO’s particular adversary, Israel.’ As Ahmad saw it, ‘the use of force only strengthened a pre-existing and pervasive sense of victimhood among Israelis, while it unified Israeli society, reinforced the most militant tendencies in Zionism, and bolstered the support of external actors.’ Ahmad did not deny the right of Palestinians to engage in armed resistance, but he believed it should be practised intelligently—to create divisions among the Israeli Jews with whom a settlement, a liberating new dispensation based on coexistence, mutual recognition, and justice, would ultimately have to be reached.

Today it is difficult to imagine an alliance between Palestinians and progressive Israeli Jews of the kind that flickered during the First Intifada. Groups pursuing joint action between Palestinians and Israelis still exist, but they are fewer than ever and deeply embattled: advocates for the binationalism sketched out by figures as various as Judah Magnes and Edward Said, Tony Judt and Azmi Bishara, have all but vanished. Nonetheless, one wonders what Ahmad would have made of Hamas’s spectacular raid on 7 October, a daring assault on Israeli bases that devolved into hideous massacres at a rave and in kibbutzes. Its short-term impact is undeniable: Operation Al-Aqsa Flood thrust the question of Palestine back on the international agenda, sabotaging the normalisation of relations between Israel and Saudi Arabia, shattering both the myth of a cost-free occupation and the myth of Israel’s invincibility. But its architects, Yahya Sinwar and Mohammed Deif, appear to have had no plan to protect Gaza’s own people from what would come next. Like Netanyahu, with whom they recently appeared on the International Criminal Court’s wanted list, they are ruthless tacticians, capable of brutal, apocalyptic vio-

lence but possessing little strategic vision. ‘Tomorrow will be different,’ Deif promised in his 7 October communiqué. He was correct. But that difference—after the initial exuberance brought about by the prison breakout—can now be seen in the ruins of Gaza.

Eight months after 7 October, Palestine remains in the grip, and at the mercy, of a furious, vengeful Jewish state, ever more committed to its colonisation project and contemptuous of international criticism, ruling over a people who have been transformed into strangers in their own land or helpless survivors, awaiting the next delivery of rations. The self-styled ‘start-up’ nation has leveraged its surveillance weapons into lucrative deals with Arab dictatorships and offers counterinsurgency training to visiting police squads, but its instinctive militarism leaves no room for new initiatives. Israel cannot imagine a future with its neighbours or its own Palestinian citizens in which it would no longer rely on force.

The ‘Iron Wall’ is not simply a defence strategy: it is Israel’s comfort zone. Netanyahu’s brinkmanship with Iran and Hizbullah is more than a bid to remain in power; it is a classical extension of Moshe Dayan’s policy of ‘active defence’. The violence will not cease unless the US cuts off the delivery of arms and forces Israel’s hand. This isn’t likely to happen anytime soon: Netanyahu is due to address Congress on 24 July, after receiving an unctuous, bipartisan invitation to share his ‘vision for defending democracy, combating terror and establishing a just and lasting peace in the region’. Biden’s call for a ceasefire has been met with another humiliating rejection by Netanyahu, who knows that the administration isn’t about to suspend military aid or observe any of its own ‘red lines’. But the encampment movement, and the growing dissent among progressive Democratic leaders from Rashida Tlaib to Bernie Sanders, foreshadows a future in which Washington will no longer provide weapons and diplomatic cover for Israel’s crimes. Whether Palestinians will be able to hold onto their lands until that day, in the face of the settler zealots and ethnic cleansers who have captured the Israeli state, remains to be seen.

Adam Shatz is the US editor of the London Review of Books. He is the author of Writers and Missionaries: Essays on the Radical Imagination and The Rebel’s Clinic: The Revolutionary Lives of Frantz Fanon. His LRB podcast series, Human Conditions, considers revolutionary thought in the 20th century through conversations with Judith Butler, Pankaj Mishra, and Brent Hayes Edwards.

Grief

ELAHEH FARMAND

Grief is magnetic and magenta
 heavy and dark, solid and fluid
 Grief is a heavy suitcase
 Grief is mother's impromptu tears, outbursts, unexpected hugs
 Grief, unlike my father's casket, cannot be buried
 Grief is a long train ride, with many mid-way stops
 Grief is a shadow, always following, always ahead
 Grief is untimely laughter and bursts of energy
 Grief is unkind
 Grief is a strange friend
 hollow and full
 Grief can only be understood
 by those who experience it
 Grief is a cruel blessing in disguise
 Grief is a long heartache
 Grief is an invitation
 into a new portal of self

Elaheh Farmand is an Iranian immigrant and writer. In 2016, she founded the series, "Immigrants & Exile: Stories of Nostalgia & Longing". The series gives space for people to share their experiences of nostalgia, exile, and longing. Elaheh fights for and dreams of a society restructured to place people's needs and wellbeing before profits. She is occasionally nostalgic for her childhood in Iran, but focuses her energy on organizing, connecting with her community, her family and friends.

Editors' note: Our dear comrade and contributing editor Elaheh Farmand lost her father recently. She wrote this poem expressing her grief. We extend our condolences to her and her family.

Their Rules-Based International Order Is the Rule of the Mafia

VIJAY PRASHAD

The skin is the largest organ of the human body. It covers our entire surface, at some points only as thin as a piece of paper and at other points about half as thick as a credit card. The skin, which protects us from all manner of germs and other harmful elements, is fragile and unable to defend humans from the dangerous weapons we have made over time. The ancient blunt axe will break the skin with a heavy blow, while a 2000-pound MK-84 'dumb bomb' made by General Dynamics will not only obliterate the skin, but the entire human body.

Despite a 24 May order from the International Court of Justice (ICJ), the Israeli military continues to bomb the southern part of Gaza, particularly the city of Rafah. In blatant disregard of the ICJ's order, on 27 May Israel struck a tent city in Rafah and murdered forty-five civilians. US President Joe Biden said on 9 March that an Israeli attack on Rafah would be his 'red line', but—even after this tent massacre—the Biden administration has insisted that no such line has been violated.

At a press conference on 28 May, communications advisor to the US National Security Agency John Kirby was asked how the US would respond if a strike by the US armed forces killed forty-five civilians and injured two hundred others. Kirby responded: 'We have conducted airstrikes in places like Iraq and Afghanistan, where tragically we caused civilian casualties. We did the same thing'. To defend Israel's latest massacre, Washington has chosen to make a startling admission. Given that the ICJ has ruled that it is 'plausible' that Israel is conducting a genocide in Gaza, could it be said that the US is guilty of the same in Iraq and Afghanistan?

In 2006, the International Criminal Court (ICC) began to assess the possibility of war crimes in Iraq and Afghanistan, and then, in 2014 and 2017, respectively, opened formal investigations into crimes committed in both countries. However, neither Israel nor the United States are signatories to the 2002 Rome Statute, which established the ICC. Rather than sign the statute, the US Congress passed the American Service-Members' Protection Act – known informally as the 'Hague Invasion Act'—which legally authorizes the US government to 'use all means necessary' to protect its troops from ICC prosecutors. Since Article 98 of the Rome Statute does not require states to turn over wanted personnel to a third party if they have signed an immunity agreement with that party, the US government has encouraged states to sign 'Article 98 agreements' to give its troops immunity from prosecution. Still, this did not deter ICC Prosecutor Fatou Bensouda (who held the post from 2012–2021) from studying evidence and issuing a preliminary report in 2016 on war crimes in Afghanistan.

Afghanistan joined the ICC in 2003, giving the ICC and Bensouda jurisdiction to conduct their investigation. Even though it signed an Article 98 agreement with Afghanistan in 2002, the US government fervently attacked the ICC's investigation

and warned Bensouda and her family that they would face personal repercussions if she continued with the investigation. In April 2019, the US revoked Bensouda's entry visa. Days later, a panel of ICC judges ruled against Bensouda's request to proceed with a war crimes investigation in Afghanistan, stating that such an investigation would 'not serve the interests of justice'.

Staff at the ICC were dismayed by the court's decision and eager to challenge it, but could not get support from the justices. In June 2019, Bensouda filed a request to appeal the ICC's decision not to pursue the investigation into war crimes in Afghanistan. Bensouda's appeal was joined by various groups from Afghanistan, including the Afghan Victims' Families Association and the Afghanistan Forensic Science Organization. In September 2019, the Pre-Trial Chamber of the ICC ruled that the appeal could go forward.

The US government was enraged. On 11 June 2020, US President Donald Trump signed Executive Order 13928, which authorized his government to freeze ICC officials' assets and ban them and their families from entering the United States. In September 2020, the US imposed sanctions on Bensouda, a national of Gambia, and senior ICC diplomat Phakiso Mochochoko, a national of Lesotho. The American Bar Association condemned these sanctions, but they were not revoked.

The US government eventually repealed the sanctions in April 2021, after Bensouda left her post and was replaced by the British lawyer Karim Khan in February 2021. In September 2021, ICC Prosecutor Karim Khan said that while his office would continue to investigate war crimes by the Taliban and the Islamic State in Afghanistan, it would 'deprioritise other aspects of this investigation'. This awkward phrasing simply meant that the ICC would no longer investigate war crimes committed by the United States and its allies from the North Atlantic Treaty Organization. The ICC had been sufficiently brought to heel.

Prosecutor Khan again demonstrated his partial application of justice and fealty to the Global North ruling elites when he rushed into the conflict in Ukraine and began an investigation into war crimes by Russia just four days after its invasion in February 2022. Within a year, Khan would apply for warrants for the arrest of Russian President Vladimir Putin and his Commissioner for Children's Rights Maria Lvova-Belova, which were issued in March 2023. Specifically, they were charged with colluding to abduct children from Ukrainian orphanages and children's care homes and take them to Russia, where—it was alleged—these children were 'given for adoption'. Ukraine, Khan said, 'is a crime scene'.

Khan would use no such words when it came to Israel's murderous assault on Palestinians in Gaza. Even after more than 15,000 Palestinian children had been killed (rather than 'adopted' from a war zone), Khan failed to pursue warrants for the arrest of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and his military subordinates. When Khan visited Israel in November–December 2023, he warned about 'excesses' but suggested that since 'Israel has trained lawyers who advise commanders', they could prevent any horrendous violations of international humanitarian law.

By May 2024, the sheer scale of Israel's brutality in Gaza finally forced the ICC to take up the issue. The orders from the ICJ, the outrage expressed by numerous governments of the Global South, and the cascading protests in country after coun-

try together motivated the ICC to act. On 20 May, Khan held a press conference where he said that he filed applications for the arrest of Hamas leaders Yahya Sinwar, Mohammed Diab Ibrahim al-Masri, and Ismail Haniyeh and Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu and his head of the military, Yoav Gallant. Israel's Attorney General Gali Baharav-Miara said that the ICC accusations against Netanyahu and Gallant are 'baseless' and that Israel will not comply with any ICC warrant. For decades now, Israel—like the United States—has rejected any attempt to apply international humanitarian law to its actions. The 'rules-based international order' has always provided immunity for the United States and its close allies, an immunity whose hypocrisy has increasingly been revealed. It is this double standard that has provoked the collapse of the US-driven world order.

Buried within Khan's press statement is an interesting fragment: 'I insist that all attempts to impede, intimidate, or improperly influence the officials of this Court must cease immediately'. Eight days later, on 20 May, *The Guardian*—in collaboration with other periodicals—published an investigation that revealed Israel's use of 'intelligence agencies to surveil, hack, pressure, smear, and allegedly threaten senior ICC staff in an effort to derail the court's inquiries'. Yossi Cohen, the former head of Israel's spy agency, Mossad, personally harassed and threatened Bensouda (Khan's predecessor), warning her, 'You don't want to be getting into things that could compromise your security or that of your family'. Furthermore, *The Guardian* noted that 'Between 2019 and 2020, the Mossad had been actively seeking compromising information on the prosecutor and took an interest in her family members'. 'Took an interest' is a euphemistic way of saying gathered information on her family—including through a sting operation against her husband Philip Bensouda—to blackmail and frighten her. These are clichéd mafia tactics.

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‘This Is A Sharp Time’ — Israel’s ‘Day Of Joy’

MEDIA LENS

In his very last article, ‘We are Spartacus’, published just a month before his death in December, John Pilger included a quote that exactly captured the truth of our time: “‘This is a sharp time, now, a precise time...’” wrote Arthur Miller in *The Crucible*, “‘We live no longer in the dusky afternoon when evil mixed itself with good and befuddled the world.’”

No one saw more clearly than Pilger that the West’s use of ultra-violence to impose its brutal, zero-sum version of ‘international order’ is now completely out in the open. Even the blurred obfuscations of the state-corporate media lens are no longer able to hide the reality of who ‘we’ are.

Consider US Senator Lindsey Graham last month. With tens of thousands of civilians dead in Gaza, Graham dug down to some dark place and said on NBC:

‘Can I say this? Why is it OK for America to drop two nuclear bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki to end their existential threat war? Why was it OK for us to do that? I thought it was OK.’

Graham was mistaken; it wasn’t ‘OK’ at all. But anyway, his point:

‘So, Israel, do whatever you have to do to survive as a Jewish state. Whatever you have to do.’ (Original emphasis)

The implication was clear. Past and future massacres of civilians—notably of women and children—were declared, not just ‘OK’, but unavoidable:

‘I think it’s impossible to mitigate civilian deaths in Gaza as long as Hamas uses their own population as human shields. I’ve never seen in the history of warfare such blatant efforts by an enemy—Hamas—to put civilians at risk.’

Graham concluded:

‘The last thing you want to do is reward this behavior.’

Israel reining in its US-supplied firepower to kill fewer civilians would be a ‘reward’ for bad behaviour.

Perhaps you remember Western politicians expressing such unapologetic savagery in the face of genocidal killing. We do not.

And Graham is not alone. Also in May, US Congressman Brian Mast called on Israel to devastate Rafah, where 600,000 children were then sheltering from Israeli bombs:

‘I think Israel should go in there and kick the shit out of them, just absolutely destroy them, their infrastructure, level anything that they touch.’

Three weeks later, on 27 May, media reported that at least eight Israeli missiles had slammed into Rafah’s camp of plastic tents. Refugees, mostly women and

children, were burned alive. Fairness and Accuracy in Reporting described the carnage many of us saw for ourselves on social media: ‘A boy cries in horror and fear as he watches his father’s tent burn with him inside. A man holds up the body of his charred, now-headless baby, wandering around, not knowing what to do or where to go. An injured, starving child convulses in pain as a medic struggles to find a vein for an IV in her emaciated arm.’

Worse was to come on 8 June when Israeli forces launched a raid to rescue four hostages from the Nuseirat refugee camp in central Gaza. At least 274 Palestinians were killed with 698 wounded. The EU’s top diplomat Josep Borrell described the assault as a ‘massacre’, while the UN’s aid chief Martin Griffiths spoke of ‘shredded bodies on the ground’. Francesca Albanese, the United Nations Special Rapporteur on the occupied Palestinian territories, posted on X:

‘The #Nuseirat massacre will go down in history as one of the most appalling examples of disdain for Palestinian life in one of the most well-documented and boasted about genocides in history.’

The BBC headline reporting this massacre read merely:

‘Four hostages rescued in Gaza as hospitals say scores killed in Israeli strikes’

It was not at all surprising that the BBC mentioned the four hostages rescued ahead of the ‘scores’—in fact, nearly 300—Palestinians killed. News of the 274 Palestinian victims quickly dropped down the news page. Former *Guardian* journalist Jonathan Cook commented:

‘BBC News’ main report on Saturday night breathlessly focused on the celebrations of the families of the freed captives, treating the massacre of Palestinians as an afterthought.’

Compare the BBC’s headline with one supplied by the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights:

‘UN experts condemn outrageous disregard for Palestinian civilians during Israel’s military operation in Nuseirat’

Conditioned as we are by the ‘mainstream’ habit of normalising the unthinkable, we might not find the BBC headline all that biased—they just reported the facts. But just imagine if the identities of the civilians killed and the hostages rescued were reversed. While the deaths of 274 Israelis would have been a seismic event for the BBC for days and weeks, the liberation of four Palestinian hostages would hardly have been mentioned and certainly not celebrated. Journalists would have dreaded giving the impression that the release of four Palestinian hostages in any way justified the killing of so many Israelis. This *New York Times* headline would be unthinkable:

‘Hostages Reunited with Family After Israel Military Operation

‘Scores of Palestinians were killed, hospital officials said, as Israel carried out an intense military campaign to free four hostages’

Likewise, this *Washington Post* headline:

'Four Israeli hostages rescued alive; at least '210 people killed in Gaza, officials say'

Is it not clear how the value of one group of human beings is relentlessly raised above the other? *The Washington Post* even commented:

'For Israel, a rare day of joy amid bloodshed as 4 hostages rescued alive.'

If the identities were reversed, the idea that a day on which 274 Israelis had been killed might be declared 'a rare day of joy' would be deemed unthinkable, obscene.

Despite the many hundreds of dead and wounded civilians, and so many massacres of civilians over so many months, headlines in *The Sunday Times* described the massacre as a 'daring raid', a 'surgical strike' that resulted in 'celebrations'.

Although the Nuseirat massacre clearly trashed President Biden's supposed 'red lines', US national security adviser Jake Sullivan also described the attack as a 'daring operation'. German Chancellor Olaf Scholz called it an 'important sign of hope'. With hundreds of 'shredded bodies on the ground', British Prime Minister Rishi Sunak expressed his 'huge relief'.

How Many Gazans 'Support Their Murdering, Raping Masters'?

For seven months, all political writers using social media have been relentlessly assailed by footage of tiny Palestinian children (often orphans) burned, bleeding, crushed, shaking in pain and terror, bits of broken skull protruding from their heads. We know we are living 'in a sharp time' when the *Telegraph's* Associate Editor Camilla Tominey can respond to all of this on 18 May with a piece titled:

'Admitting Gazan refugees would be proof that Britain has a death wish

'We have no idea how many Palestinians support their murdering, raping masters'

Tominey wrote with utmost brutality:

'We took in Ukrainians in part because we have a security agreement with Ukraine and can be fairly certain that none of those fleeing the Russian invasion are terrorists.

'Sadly the same cannot be said for occupants of a country run by Hamas. Regardless of their medical — or other — qualifications, we have no idea how many Gazans support their murdering, raping masters, or how many have been further radicalised by war.

'It would surely be better if these Labour MPs focused on our own problems, without burdening Britain yet further with someone else's.'

Britain should not assume the 'burden' of helping injured babies and tiny, traumatised infants, when we have no way of knowing how many might 'support their murdering, raping masters'.

Regarding rape, *The Times* discussed (7 June) a United Nations report submitted earlier this year by Pramilla Patten, the UN secretary-general's special representative on sexual violence during and since the Hamas massacres of 7 October:

'Patten made it clear there was sufficient evidence of acts of sexual violence to merit full and proper investigation and expressed her shock at the brutality of the violence. The report also confirmed Israeli authorities were unable to provide much of the evidence that political leaders had insisted existed. In all the Hamas video footage Patten's team had watched and all the photographs they had seen, there were no depictions of rape. We hired a leading Israeli dark-web researcher to look for evidence of those images, including footage deleted from public sources. None could be found.

'The report would prove confusing to the Israeli political establishment. On the one hand, it gives substantial and substantiated credence to the sexual assault claims; on the other it does not show them to be systematic and specifically says Israel has been unable to produce evidence it has claimed to possess of Hamas's written orders to rape. Patten also asked that Israel investigate "credible allegations" of rape and sexual violence against Palestinian women and girls gathered by the UN's legal mandate mission in the Palestinian territories.'

The Times also cited Orit Sulitzeanu, the executive director of Israel's Association of Rape Crisis Centres:

'The first letter that I received from the government of Israel talked about hundreds or thousands of cases of brutal sexual violence perpetrated against men, women and children. I have not found anything like that.'

Tominey smeared the entire Palestinian population with this comment:

'It is also worth noting that a Palestinian student has already had her visa revoked after saying she was "full of joy" after the October 7 attacks. Dana Abuqamar, 19, a law student at the University of Manchester, said that she was "proud that Palestinian resistance has come to this point" after the atrocities. It would be naive to believe that the average Palestinian wishing to come to the UK thinks much differently.'

Tominey linked to an earlier *Telegraph* article by Isabel Oakeshott from October 2023, which sympathised with the plight of the Palestinians in Gaza, but added:

'To usher in an additional cohort of traumatised people, many, if not most, of whom will not share our values; will not speak our language; and will not find it easy to build new lives here, would be insane. With the right support, most would probably integrate — but we must face up to the uncomfortable truth that a very small number will not wish us well, and may repay our generosity by fomenting division and hatred in our communities — or worse.'

Oakeshott offered the warning of protesters who 'appear convinced that the plight of the people of Gaza is the fault of the Israelis, as opposed to the cruel Iranian-sponsored militia that controls the territory'. This, she said, 'has grave impli-

cations for community cohesion. How much more dangerous will this already febrile situation become, if we naively import thousands more people brutalised by war and confused about who is to blame for their plight?’

Oakeshott’s brutal sign-off:

‘the UK does not have a duty to *take a single one* of those escaping the fall-out’. (Our emphasis)

Media brutality feeds party political brutality, which feeds further media brutality... and down we go. Peter Osborne, former chief political commentator of *The Daily Telegraph*, commented recently:

‘One of the historical roles of the Conservative Party has been to act as a prophylactic against fascist and far-right forces which, history shows us, have always lurked not far under the surface in British society.

‘It is no longer playing that role. The Conservative Party is falling into the hands of the far right before our eyes.’

In his conclusion to a separate piece, Osborne posts an ominous warning on the emerging political culture of this ‘sharp time’:

‘For the first time in my life it is possible to look forward and envisage a sequence of events that might turn Britain fascist.’ (‘Peter Osborne’s Diary—The Dark Shadow of Fascism’, *Byline Times*, July 2024)

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Israel’s Unending Genocidal War on the Palestinians

VIJAY PRASHAD

AFTER seven months, the lead prosecutor at the International Criminal Court (ICC), Karim Khan KC, decided to announce that he would be looking into framing warrants regarding Israel’s genocidal war in Gaza. With nearly 40,000 people dead and 10,000 missing, and with over two million people displaced and threatened with death from bombs or from disease, this war is one of the worst in recent years. Israel’s military has deliberately cut off Gaza from food and water, and has systematically bombed institutions of the state and civil society so that any return of the displaced will be more than difficult.

If the bombing ended today, it would take fourteen years to clear out the unexploded ordinance. It would take an unimaginable amount of money and resources to rebuild Gaza so that it could return to some measure of normalcy. Karim Khan is months too late with his statement, but never too late to charge high officials of the Israeli government with war crimes.

Rafah

The Israeli armed forces had told the Palestinians in Gaza that they should abandon their homes north of Wadi Gaza and head to the south. Then, when the Israelis felt that they had largely completed their mission in Gaza City, including destroying all the major cultural and humanitarian institutions there (universities and hospitals, for example), they informed the Palestinians to leave Khan Younis—the second largest city in Gaza—and head to Rafah, the Gaza Strip’s third largest city. This is precisely what over a million Palestinians did in the matter of a few days. They rushed south and then further south.

Now, the Israelis have told the Palestinians in Rafah to leave large parts of that city and head toward the coastline. There is simply no place for people to go, since the Israelis have seized the Rafah crossing into Egypt and they have blocked access to the borderlands near Israel (including the Kerem Shalom crossing). In a hurry, over 800,000 Palestinians have left Rafah and headed toward the Mediterranean Sea. They are living in make-shift shelters, unable to find decent food and water. Famine and disease are twins in this situation.

Northern Gaza

Between October 2023 and January 2024, the Israeli aircraft and tanks pumelled northern Gaza, particularly Gaza City. The level of bombardment was stark, with the Israelis—well-armed by the United States and the United Kingdom—hitting any building that they felt should be a target. Entire neighbourhoods in Gaza City have been levelled, and entire families have been wiped out. One of the areas particularly hard hit from the air was the Jabaliya refugee camp, set up in 1948 by those who had been forcibly displaced by the new Israeli state. Israel’s air force was unrelenting, hitting this entirely civilian area with maximum force. When the Israelis left the camp in early February 2024, al-Jazeera’s Anas al-Sharif went and spoke

to residents who told him, ‘Nothing was spared. Land, houses, and trees were all destroyed. Nothing is habitable, but we will remain steadfast and unwavering with our strong determination.’

In May 2024, the Israelis returned to bomb the camp, once more killing civilians in this highly congested area. During the bombardment, Ibrahim Khaled, who lives in the camp, said by WhatsApp, ‘Today is the most difficult in terms of the occupation’s bombardment; air strikes, tank shelling have been going on non-stop’. It is also clear that the resistance forces in the northern half of Gaza have not been totally defeated. They continue to harass any Israeli ground force, which is why in January 2024 the Israeli military withdrew five brigades out of Gaza and started a ‘third phase’ in the war (which would mainly include aerial bombardment).

The ‘first phase’ was the shelling and aerial bombardment of Gaza from October 7 to 27, and then the ‘second phase’ was the ground invasion into Gaza. While Israel tried to suggest that this shift into the ‘third phase’ was always part of their plan, it is clear that they had to reconsider sending troops into Gaza after they began to take casualties (twenty-four soldiers were killed on January 22, which is roughly when the Israelis moved to the ‘third phase’).

Israeli Ruthlessness

Karim Khan of the ICC might frame warrants for the arrest of high officials of the current Israeli government. However, the behaviour of Benjamin Netanyahu (who has been prime minister for over sixteen years, between 1996 and 1999, then 2009–2021, and finally from 2022) is not an individual act itself but rooted in the structure of Israel’s apartheid system and its ruthlessness toward Palestinians that is manifest in the plausible nature of the genocide (as noted by the International Court of Justice).

The genocidal intent goes back to the early days of Gun Zionism in Israel. It was an Israeli prime minister—Golda Meir—who denied the existence of the Palestinians in 1969 (‘There was no such thing as Palestinians’) and it was another Israeli prime minister—Yitzhak Rabin—who instructed his commanders to ‘break the bones’ of young Palestinians who threw stones at the Israeli forces in the first intifada of 1989–91. This attitude structures the conduct of the Israeli army, not only in Gaza but equally in East Jerusalem and the West Bank. It is this attitude that has framed the annexationist policies in the entire Occupied Palestinian Territory.

During the official Israeli army’s war on the Palestinians in Gaza, the state-backed illegal settlers have been going on rampage upon rampage against the Palestinian villages and towns in the West Bank. Between April 12–16, for instance, illegal Israeli settlers attacked the villages of al-Mughayyir, Aqraba, Beitin, Deir Dibwan, and Duma. They killed Palestinian civilians, including medical workers, and destroyed olive groves and vegetable fields.

In mid-May, illegal Israeli settlers attacked the villages of Salfit and Yatma, burning parts of homes and seizing vehicles crucial to the agricultural life of the Palestinians. These vehicles—as in the case of Nablus and Wadi Qana—were carrying grain and fodder. Along the road between Jericho and Ramallah, illegal Israeli settlers stood and threw stones at passing cars driven by Palestinians. Israeli soldiers

stood by and did nothing to intervene. The general Israeli official attitude is that these settlers will raise the price of existence for the Palestinians, who then might decide to move across the border to Jordan. It is the utter ruthlessness of the violence that defines Israeli policy, both of the State institutions and of the illegal settlers.

There has been no attempt by the Israeli government to hem in the settlers, despite several United Nations resolutions about the illegality of the settlements. The situation has become so dire that even the *New York Times* had to report on its gravity (Ronen Bergman and Mark Mazzetti, ‘The Unpunished: How Extremists Took Over Israel’, 16 May) and even Canadian and US lawmakers had to consider legal measures to prevent donations going from their countries to these settlements.

There have been several ceasefire proposals on the table, and despite the agreements from the Palestinian side, the Israelis have refused to enter a proper process. The Israelis are now convinced that they can continue this war until Hamas is destroyed, which is a ridiculous standard. Whether Hamas is able to recover from this barrage or not, the Palestinian resistance movement will remain, will regroup, and will continue to fight for the end to the occupation.

The only way for Israel to seek security is by acknowledging the demands of the Palestinians for their emancipation. Anything short of that—even the obliteration of Hamas (which was formed in 1987)—will be insufficient. And therein lies the harsh truth for Israeli society: it is unwilling to accept the Palestinians as political subjects with their demands and their hopes, and in this unwillingness the Israelis have put themselves into a genocidal logic which by itself cannot find the road to peace.

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Hearing! Hearing! Hearing!

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

“It’s dangerous to be right when the government is wrong.” —Voltaire

Hearing! Hearing! Hearing!
 Sheep-shearing/job-fearing/fictioneering—
 Chalk white, snow white, lily white, bone
 White noise ...

White noise shrouding months of live-streamed slaughter:
 Decapitated doctors; assassinated ambulance drivers;
 Wounded shrieks; dying moans—haunting screams of
 Mothers lifting what’s left of babies’ shrapnel-shredded bodies

Soundbite-grabbing; headline-stealing; Goebbels-gotcha
 Big lies disguised as hearings. Wretched klan Kabuki
 Theater of moral paupers holding tattered hand-lettered
 Signs shouting: **“WILL WORK FOR GENOCIDE!!”**

Spectacle of skunk-scented hot air. Of bleached white
 Death Panel inquisitors asking AI “Yes or No” questions—
 Gaslighting—giving great Capitalist Hill cover for
 Genocide ... Great cover for grand dragon government

Hearing! Hearing! Hearing!
 Sheep-shearing/job-fearing/fictioneering—
 Chalk white, snow white, lily white, bone
 White noise ...

Teargas tones. See-thru bomb bay bras. Revealing
 Open-hearted concern for blowing smoke in our
 Bloodshot eyes/broken hearts from seeing double
 Amputee children; mass graves; bombed hospitals

A fascist filibuster. Evil MAGAt Mamas with Charlottesville
 Umbilical cords and J6 afterbirth. A Capitalist Hill coven of
 Wicked, war-headed witches wielding one
 Weaponized word ... Posturing as friends of Jews ...

Hot air superiority/McCarthyite complement to plastic
 Cuffs; rubber bullets; flash-bang grenades; baton blows;
 Mass arrests. A search and destroy Psy-Op massacring
 Public education/educators caught in capitalist crosshairs

Hearing! Hearing! Hearing!
 Sheep-shearing/job-fearing/fictioneering—
 Chalk white, snow white, lily white, bone
 White noise ...

Airwaves saturated with antipersonnel elephant
 Excrement ... Reich brain farts escaping as thought
 Balloons in cartoons: “Wish we could go Gitmo and
 Waterboard these bitches—Show ‘em we mean business!”

Images of kaki-clad marchers chanting: “Jews will not
 Replace us!” and J-6 teeshirts emblazoned: “6 Million Was
 Not Enough” dance through minds of cruelty contest competitors
 Auditioning for Commandant of Concentration Camps 25 and 47

Hearing! Hearing! Hearing!
 Sheep-shearing/job-fearing/fictioneering—
 Chalk white, snow white, lily white, bone
 White noise ...

Shhhhhhhhhh ...
 Shhhhhhhhhh ...
 We’ve heard enough ... from the
 World’s greatest purveyor of violence.

Former forklift driver/warehouse worker/janitor, Raymond Nat Turner is a NYC poet; BAR’s Poet-in-Residence; and founder/co-leader of the jazz-poetry ensemble UpSurge!NYC. [Read other articles by Raymond Nat](#), or [visit Raymond Nat’s website](#).

Is ‘Duel’ the better 4-letter Dream word for ‘Debate?’

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

Sun drenched morning. Silver bullet-loaded, matched gold-plated
Glocks gleam above gilded dress swords. Above bump-stocked
AR-15s, strapped across slumped shoulders of two 1% men of
Limited vision. Mediocre men brandishing usurped Peoples’ Power ...

The NRA, RNC and DNC searched far and wide for an S***hole
Country—boots on the ground—who’d host the gentlemen’s
Gun-powdered dustup. The People are excited! Ticket scalpers’ pockets
Got the mumps! Pay-per view revenues explode like 2,000 lb. bombs!

Kansas City’s Arrowhead Stadium almost hosted it. Fans were a bit
Too split on who they’d ‘Tomahawk Chop’/ faux Native chant for.
Miraculously, Bechtel built Weehawken Stadium seating well over
100,000—provided Boeing bombs it/Bechtel rebuilds it ...4 yrs later ...

A Peach State nut job/aka ‘Driving Miss Crazy,’ a Rocky Mountain
State gun moll; an Empire State inquisitor; an ex-Palmetto State
Governor who scribbled, “Finish them off!” on bombs destined for
Gaza are cheerleaders chosen for the bipartisan combatants

A dock built for bringing in more supplies and equipment split apart.
Kegs of beer, pallets of peanuts and pretzels were airdropped into the
Stadium ... Standing back; standing by; looking skyward for
Snacks, Proud boys momentarily walked in Palestinian sandals ...

WE The People face fierce trillion dollar dilemmas—
Bought and bossed ones offer
Dollar store ‘solutions.’ Performative politicians promise to
“Fight like hell!” and, hopefully, spare us trauma of bipartisan
Buffoonery ... Policy-lite/Solution-absent/Mad monologues ...
Dumbed-down discourse ... disguised as debate ...

They opt instead for “Trial by combat!” For Jumbotron spectacle!
Standing back-to-back—French-style—stepping off 20 paces to
Cherry ‘red lines’ with feeble gaits ... Breathless billions watch
Worldwide! Proceeds go to
House the Unhoused; Healthcare For All; Free Education; go
To clean up rivers and oceans; to Green Jobs and empty jails ...
“Thoughts and prayers” to the loser’s family ...
Winner’s allowed—like U.S. troops in Afghanistan—to

Urinate on loser’s body; and cut off fingers for souvenirs.
Body will lie in state—wrapped in stars and stripes—
Capitalist Hill rotunda ... 21 gun-salute! Burial, Arlington
National Cemetery.

Winner gets next biggest imperialist strongman. Next biggest
Authoritarian Supreme Leader/Embassy Butcher/Nationalist
Pogrom Master—Lending new meaning to “sudden death over-
time.” Buying the International Working Class time ... to organize itself?

*Former forklift driver/warehouse worker/janitor, Raymond Nat Turner is a NYC poet; BAR’s
Poet-in-Residence; and founder/co-leader of the jazz-poetry ensemble UpSurge!NYC. [Read
other articles by Raymond Nat](#), or [visit Raymond Nat’s website](#).*

Papa Cop's Pedagogy of the Oppressor

(Apartheid state professors or SS students?)

"The policeman isn't there to create disorder; the policeman is there to preserve disorder."

—Richard J. Daley

Scholasticide? Pedicide? Infanticide? Ecocide?
Genocide? Clear which side they're on, they
Study war no more—And refuse to cave under
Weight of state—under Papa Cop Condor watch ...

Bought and bossed, Papa Cop commits to police state.
Surveillance state. Apartheid state. Real Estate. Papa
Cop commits to elephant-eared walls/eagle-eyed poles.
Commit\$ OT to embedded/invading/occupying professors.

Papa Cop's Pedagogy of the Oppressor's built on bulky
bodies of apartheid state-trained teachers. Visiting professors
of Pain Compliance—
Resurrecting Guantanamo ghosts; exorcising 'outside agitators!'

Papa Cop's Pedagogy of the Oppressor's taught by Vitamin S-
fueled scholars. Zip-tie truncheon-taser-teargas-wielding
Adjunct professors—pounding, slamming, jabbing, choking
Contagious anti-capitalist virus out of students' systems!

Papa Cop's Pedagogy is cool with Skunk Shock Troops—
J6-IOF ilk—Deputized thugs invading campuses. Cool with
brownshirt 'counter-protestors.' Cool with Capitalist Hill-
Birth Of A Nation-MAGAt hat-horned shaman-style occupiers

Papa Cop's Pedagogy of the Oppressor = U.S. Imperialism 101.
Not graduate studies, '70s Santiago. Not '04 Kabul, Baghdad,
West Bank, Gaza, Port au Prince postdoctoral studies. Not
gendering at gunpoint for peacock blue pill/weaponized warheads.

Papa Cop's Pedagogy of the Oppressor = U.S. Imperialism 101.
Not herding the handcuffed off to secluded quads and unpacking
magazines—filing reports into inquiring minds, into hungry brains—
Before hacking fingers off perforated avatars for souvenirs ...

Papa Cop's Pedagogy of the Oppressor = U.S. Imperialism 101.
Not yet beheading and urinating on ashtray torsos; on electrified
genitalia
Before disrespectfully dumping crimes into freshly dug ditches

Papa Cop's Pedagogy Of The Oppressor will not pass—
Fails— for it forgets ... or refuses to remember ... its own
Tested, failsafe formula for radicalization ... One baton
Blow= 10 teach-ins=1,000 books= A million lectures ...

*Former forklift driver/warehouse worker/janitor, Raymond Nat Turner is a NYC poet; BAR's
Poet-in-Residence; and founder/co-leader of the jazz-poetry ensemble UpSurge!NYC. [Read
other articles by Raymond Nat](#), or [visit Raymond Nat's website](#).*

United Nations Negroz

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

Lightweight, portable — wind-powered —
United Nations Negroz need no batteries.
They run quietly and smoothly; And have
small carbon footprints.

Like corporations—they are people. Plug them
into foundations or situations—like the United
Nations — and they'll run all day and all night ...
moving mouths with Wall Street/militarist messaging.

Wind them up and they'll go into combat convulsions.
Bully pulpit spasms — repeating terrorist talking points—
Ad nauseam ... intersecting and protecting
Empire ... reducing homes, hospitals, schools to rubble.

Wind them up and they'll spin! Stonewall! Gaslight! Muddle!
Jumble! Blur a weapons lab with fog of war. Wind them up and
Children become bloody cuts of meat marked: "Civilian Casualties"
"Collateral Damage—" marked down for daily "Self-Defense" sales.

United Nations Negroz come with warranties —
Money-back guarantees against breaking with
Empire and recognizing the humanity of Palestinians ...

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Notes From the Editor (continued from inside front cover)

release of Israeli hostages, and a halt to the rising disaffection of a significant number of democratic voters with his administration, voters who have registered their concerns by voting as "uncommitted" in the various Democratic primary state elections.

A key problem is Benjamin Netanyahu, the Prime Minister of Israel. He is bent on continuing the slaughter of innocent Palestinians to maintain the emergency that keeps him out of court and possibly jail that awaits him once he is out of power. What's more, the Israeli Jewish public supports his genocidal Gaza policies. Therefore, it is not accurate to suggest that a change at the helm would bring about a fundamental shift in Gaza policy. Lastly, Biden is unwilling or unable to halt military aid to Israel and force it to comply with his wishes. Yes, the administration is keen on seeking a ceasefire, but on Israel's terms that are clearly unacceptable to Hamas. Biden may also have calculated that if it cuts off military aid, it will certainly lose the election in November due to the pressure and influence of the Zionists at home. But that it may have a better chance of winning the November elections with better management of the uncommitted democratic voters via the use of rhetorical devices and minor or marginal but loud policy disagreements with Netanyahu.

The neo-McCarthyite campaign at home won't alleviate any of the above concerns. In fact, the increasing identification of Israel with genocide is undoing decades of its association with the Holocaust in the minds of the public. The harm to Zionism and Israel will be incalculable and is bound to change the trajectory of the anti-colonial struggle for Palestinian liberation. Indeed, for the first time since 1948, one can argue reasonably that we may be witnessing the beginning of a long process towards the end of the Zionist colonial project in historical Palestine.

Recall the R2P (Responsibility to Protect) principle falsely invoked in 2011 in Libya. Why not invoke it now and stop Israel from slaughtering Palestinians? Do we need a Reminding to Protect mechanism to invoke R2P when it's needed?

Racism in Israel is not limited to the treatment of Palestinians. Discrimination against Jews that are not European (Ashkenazi) is widespread. For example, in the 1950s, when many Jews from Islamic and Arab countries (Mizrahi) immigrated to Israel, they were sent to "transit" camps to be "reeducated" into Ashkenazi culture. Around 5,000 healthy babies were stolen from Mizrahi mothers and given to white families.

The U.S. Neocon's Dilemma Over Israel (*contributed by Gary Olson*)

If memory serves, Noam Chomsky once wrote that the US would do everything possible to prevent choosing between Israel and oil because in that event the choice would be oil. This worked well for some time, but now the Zionist entity has gotten out of hand with its genocidal war in Gaza and the attack on Iran's embassy in Damascus. Israel has become a dangerous liability and has, in Garland Nixon's apt phrase, changed from being a "trained guard dog to a mad dog."

The US national security neocons know that if Israel retaliates against Iran now, oil and gas prices would skyrocket — sinking Biden's re-election and cause both the American and European economies to plummet. Russia, with its ample oil and gas resources would be the winner. Let me put it this way: murdering Gazans is fine and dandy but endangering US control of Middle East oil resources is strictly beyond the pale.

Iran, a non-Arab Shiite nation has further enhanced its reputation among the Sunni Muslim masses even as its action has shaken the ruling monarchies and dictators that fear their own people and have covertly and overtly supported Israel.

Finally, what's happening in the Near East is a further contraction of the US empire. After humiliating debacles in Iraq and Afghanistan, the US attempted to weaken Russia via a proxy war in Ukraine—and failed miserably—leaving Russia stronger than ever and China poised to further weaken US global hegemony. The Zionist entity totally failed to defeat Hamas militarily or politically and its deterrence myth was shattered by Iranian missiles. For anyone seriously interested in a more peaceful and just world, all this is a cause for cautious optimism.

Achieving gender equality is indispensable to liberatory projects. Iranian women have struggled since the 1979 revolution to regain some lost rights and advance in others. They have progressed greatly but have yet to achieve full equality in law, not unlike women elsewhere, including the US, where the state has recently attacked their reproductive rights. The recent Women, Life, Freedom movement in Iran promised greater freedom from gender repression. The anti-regime opposition in the Iranian diaspora in the US however tried to weaponize the movement for their own mostly reactionary political agendas and some among them even urged violent tactics to bring about regime change. In our view, this ill-served the movement by giving the state ready-made reasons to repress the movement. Nevertheless, the Iranian state afterwards adopted a less restrictive approach to the issue of veiling not because it favored it but as a concession to the steadfastness of the movement and the broad public support it had enjoyed.

The state should have adopted this orientation as a formal or declared policy. Instead, it chose to move backward in 2024 as it began to implement coercive veiling policies in a campaign known as “Noor” or light. This does not serve either the state or the public interest and must be opposed. With the death of Iran's president in what appears to have been a helicopter accident in May and the new elections in Iran next week, there may be a chance that the new president could move in the opposite direction as all six approved candidates, all men, have spoken critically of the state's recent harsher gender policies.

Many in the Iranian opposition diaspora communities in the US who have proclaimed themselves as champions of Women, Life, Freedom are not to be trusted. Most of them have been silent about (if not supportive of) the US-backed Israeli genocide in Gaza with 70% of the killed, injured, maimed, starving, and sick being women and children. They have also remained silent about the repression and arrests of several thousand anti-genocide students and faculty on US campuses. Their human rights advocacy only applies to Iran. And like the US and Western countries in general, they apply a double standard and at best engage in a selective approach and at worst seek to weaponize human rights for their agendas. They too, like the Western states, and the US protestations, need to be seen for what they are and rejected as hypocritical at best and motivated by other (and hidden) considerations at worst.

Since the 2016 Paris Agreement, the largest global Banks have given nearly \$7 trillion to the fossil fuel industry. Bank of America poured nearly \$34 billion into fossil fuel financing in 2023 alone.

Join us via Zoom 7:00–9:00 PM on Fridays
for political discussions and Thursdays to watch
and discuss significant films and politics.

(Zoom link moravian.zoom.us/j/8075321907)



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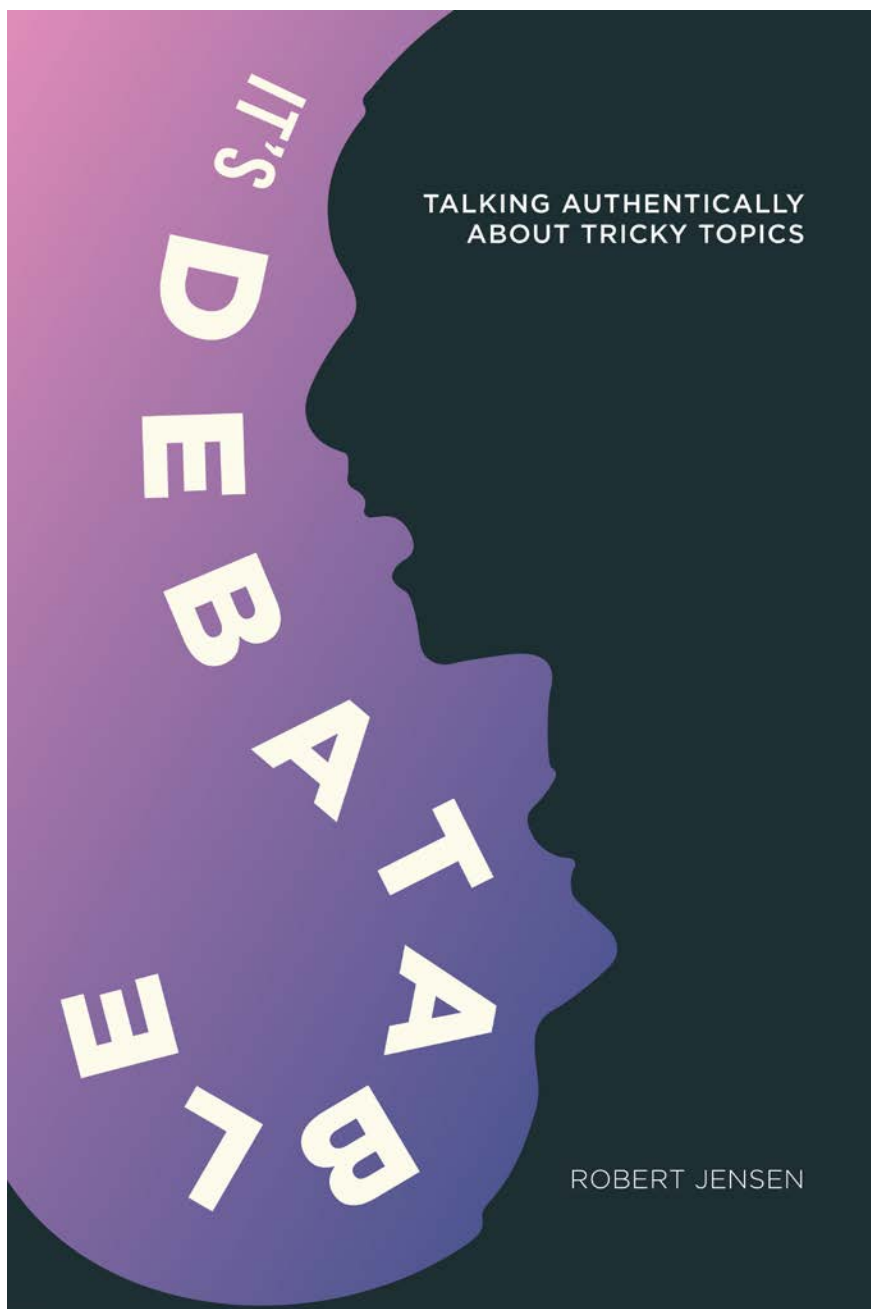
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The cover of Robert Jensen's new book. (Olive Branch Press, August 2024)

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